



BUDGIE · MELOPSITTACUS UNDULATUS

Keep your budgie the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: cage setup, a pellet-forward diet and how to get there, household hazards, hens and eggs, and the health pages that decide how long a budgie lives.

INSIDE

- ✓ Cage size, bar spacing, and the household fumes to keep away from a bird
- ✓ Pellet conversion schedules, safe food lists, and the never-feed list
- ✓ Sexing by cere, a daily gram-scale routine, and an egg binding page
- ✓ Seven health pages, a symptom table, and fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets

51 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
The Species, Colors, Size & Lifespan	5

SECTION 02 · HOUSING & ENVIRONMENT

Cage Size, Bar Spacing & Placement	6
Perches, Dishes & What to Leave Out	7
Temperature, Light & Sleep	8
Air Quality: Fumes & Airborne Hazards	9
Metals, Pets, Plants & Everyday Traps	10
Cleaning & Hygiene	11

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet: Pellets, Seed & Grit	12
Converting a Seed Eater to Pellets	13
Vegetables, Fruit & Fresh Food	14
Treats, Supplements & the Never-Feed List	15
Weight, Body Condition & the Daily Scale	16

SECTION 04 · HANDLING & BEHAVIOR

Handling & Taming	17
One Budgie or Two, Flock Needs & Company	18
Body Language & Normal Behavior	19
Enrichment & Common Mistakes	20
Flight & Wing Clipping	21
Nails, Beak, Blood Feathers & First Aid	22

SECTION 05 · ARRIVAL & LIFE STAGES

Choosing a Budgie	23
Quarantine & the First Vet Visit	24
Sexing by Cere & the Color Exceptions	25
Hens, Hormones & Chronic Egg Laying	26
Egg Binding	27
Molt & Seasonal Changes	28

SECTION 06 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Red Flags & Finding a Vet	29
Obesity, Fatty Liver, Lipomas & Tumors	30
Breathing Problems, Psittacosis & Goiter	31
Polyomavirus, French Molt & Beak and Feather Disease	32
Scaly Face Mites, Canker & Avian Gastric Yeast	33
Feather Plucking & Feather Loss	34
Reading Droppings & Water	35

SECTION 07 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	36
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	37

SECTION 08 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	38
First 30 Days	39
Symptom Quick Reference	40
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	41
Power Outages, Heat, Travel & Transport	42
Pet-Sitter Sheet	43
Owner Log	44
Equipment & Vet Log	45
Enrichment Checklist & Log	46

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to L	47
Glossary, M to Z	48
Sources	49
Where the Sources Disagree	50
Version History & About	51

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A budgie and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read the profile and housing pages, 4 to 11, before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the cage on page 6, which people buy small and replace, and whether you bring home one budgie or two on page 18. Settle both, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 38 to buy once instead of twice.

If your budgie is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, then read page 13 if the bird is on a seed mix: diet drives most of the health problems on the health pages, and the change takes days to months, so starting it today matters more than finishing this book first. If anything looks wrong, go straight to Red Flags on page 29.

Print these first

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|--|--|
| ☐ Page 36: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 43: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 37: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 44: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 45: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 41: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 46: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

A budgie is sold as the cheap, easy starter bird, and a lot of the advice in circulation was written to match that price rather than the animal: seed-only feeding, a cage the bird cannot fly across, and a kitchen as the cage spot. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and published sources listed on page 49.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is a vet call, not a page in this book, and a budgie hides illness until it is far along. Find an avian vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Melopsittacus undulatus</i> . Sold in the United States as a parakeet, and elsewhere as a budgerigar or budgie. Same bird.
Adult size	About 7 in (18 cm); 25 to 35 g
Captive lifespan	7 to 15 years; the oldest documented bird lived 29 years, 2 months
Native range	The semi-arid interior of Australia, where huge nomadic flocks follow rainfall and seed
Diet type	A grass-seed eater in the wild; in captivity 60 to 80% pellets, with vegetables and a little fruit (page 12)
Cage, one bird	18×18×18 in (46×46×46 cm) as an absolute minimum; 30×18×18 in (76×46×46 cm) for a pair. Wider beats taller.
Bar spacing	Half an inch (1.3 cm) or less
Room temperature	65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C), with 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C) ideal. No drafts, direct sun or sudden swings.
Darkness and light	10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness every night. Without unfiltered sunlight, a full-spectrum UV (ultraviolet) light made for birds for 10 to 12 hours a day.
Sexing	By cere color in an adult of a standard color; some color varieties need a DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) test (page 25)
Handling difficulty	Beginner; a hand-raised bird may step up on day one
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$165 to \$465 for a complete starter setup, bird included (\$20 to \$80 of it), plus \$45 to \$65 for the first avian vet exam. A bare-minimum first year comes to about \$390. Every line is on page 38.

Monthly ongoing

About \$19 to \$55 for food, toys and perches, with the yearly well-bird exam spread across the months.

THE LINE ITEM PEOPLE LEAVE OUT

Avian vets are scarcer and pricier than dog or cat vets, and pet insurance is rarely available for a budgie. Tests add to the exam, an emergency exam alone is \$50 to \$75 before any treatment, and emergency treatment or surgery runs \$100 to \$1,500 or more. Set money aside for it.

Fun facts worth knowing

- A budgie named Puck holds the record for the largest vocabulary of any bird: an estimated 1,728 words before his death in 1994.
- A budgie's beak never stops growing, which is why it needs something safe to chew on.
- Budgies are prey animals and hide illness, so a bird that looks sick has usually been sick for a while.

The species, colors, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species, three names

The pet budgie is *Melopsittacus undulatus*. "Parakeet" is a broad, non-scientific word for many small to medium parrots with long tails, and a United States pet store that sells a bird labeled only "parakeet" is almost always selling a budgie. Ring-necked and monk parakeets are different species entirely. In the wild the budgie lives in open grassland, scrubland and open woodland in the interior of Australia, in nomadic flocks that can run to thousands, eating grass seeds, berries and other plant matter. It feeds on or near the ground, taking whichever seeds are in season. It is small, swift and highly social, and it is the best-selling pet bird in the world.

Colors and types

Standard blue and standard gray budgies follow the cere-color rule on page 25. Pastel and solid-color mutations do not, because their cere stays pinkish lavender for life. Alongside the ordinary pet bird there is a heavier show type, bred for exhibition. The care in this package applies to all of them.

Size and age

Length	About 7 in (18 cm)
Weight	25 to 35 g for a healthy adult. Your own bird's settled weight matters more than the range (page 16).
Telling age	Two features date a budgie at a glance: the barring on the forehead recedes as the bird ages, and the iris, dark in a youngster, turns gray. Full forehead bars and solid dark eyes mean a young bird.
Adult cere color	Settles between 6 and 12 months old

Lifespan

7 to 15 years is typical in captivity. Diet drives most of the health problems that shorten a budgie's life, which is why so much of this package is about food. A budgie bought for a 10-year-old can still be on its perch when that child leaves for college, so plan for the whole span: the routine, the cage and an avian vet for every one of those years.

Talking and noise

Budgies are among the best talkers for their size, and single males tend to be the best of all. Their constant chatter sits at a gentle, background volume that most households barely notice, much softer than a cockatiel. Most pet birds are loudest at dawn and dusk, a habit that comes from wild contact calling.

FLOCK FIRST

Everything about a budgie follows from being a flock bird. It wants company all day, it feels safest with a wall at its back, and movement above or behind it reads as a predator. The housing and handling pages are built on those three facts.

Cage size, bar spacing & placement

The purchase that is hardest to undo, and the one number that is a safety limit.

Size and shape

An absolute minimum for a single budgie is 18×18×18 in (46×46×46 cm). A wide flight-style cage serves a budgie far better: closer to 30×18×18 in (76×46×46 cm) for a pair, with 32 in (81 cm) or more of length a genuine improvement over the minimum. The cage sold as a "budgie starter cage" is usually a bare minimum at best.

Prioritize width over height. A budgie flies side to side in short bursts rather than climbing, so a tall, narrow cage wastes the exact space it would use, while a wide one gives it real flying room. A cage sized for a pair from the start stays the same cage if a second bird joins later.

Bar spacing: half an inch or less

A SAFETY LIMIT, NOT A PREFERENCE

Bars must be half an inch (1.3 cm) or closer. Anything wider risks a budgie squeezing through and escaping, or catching its head while it tries. Avoid round cages entirely.

Check the finish before buying. A cage that uses zinc or lead in its finish is toxic if the bird ingests it through normal chewing and preening, and galvanized wire is a zinc source (page 10). Stainless steel or powder-coated hardware avoids the problem.

Where the cage goes

PLACE	WHY
Against a wall, at or near eye level	Movement above or behind a caged bird triggers a real predator-response fear that makes taming much harder. An open, exposed spot is the worst choice.
Somewhere the household is	A budgie is a flock bird. A single bird needs substantial daily interaction, and a cage where people pass gives it some of it.
Never the kitchen	Overheated nonstick cookware gives off fumes that are frequently fatal to birds, with little warning. Keep birds out of the kitchen entirely.
Off drafts, out of direct sun	A caged bird cannot move out of the sun, and budgies have no sweat glands. Avoid sudden temperature swings too.
A spot that can be made dark	A cage in the room where the household spends its evenings gets lamp and screen light through the hours the bird should be asleep. A separate sleep cage fixes that.

BUY THE CAGE BEFORE THE BIRD

Set it up and stock it with dishes and perches before pickup day. A cage that is too small or poorly laid out on day one gets used as it is far more often than it gets fixed later, and the bird spends less time in a travel carrier.

Perches, dishes & what to leave out

What goes in the cage, where, and what does not.

Perches: variety matters more than material

Provide a mix of diameters, textures and materials: natural branches such as manzanita, apple and willow, plus some rope perches for texture. A foot that has to adjust its grip through the day stays healthy. Smooth wooden dowels as the only perch give a foot one surface and one diameter, which contributes to arthritis and pressure sores over time. Skip sandpaper perch covers: they do not file nails effectively and can irritate the feet.

A bird that stands on rough, varied perches wears its nails down through normal use. One confined to smooth dowels or the cage floor needs trims more often (page 22).

Layout for flight

A budgie cage has one flight path, end to end, and the layout either keeps it open or fills it. Toys go around the edges near the perches, never in the middle, because a swing or hanging toy in the center blocks the only flight the bird gets inside the cage. Put perches at opposite ends so the bird flies between them, and set the food and water dishes at opposite ends too, so eating and then drinking means a flight each time.

Dishes

Position food and water dishes away from perches so droppings do not end up in them. That small detail meaningfully cuts cleaning and health risk. A budgie shells its seed and leaves the husks behind, so a dish can look full while holding almost nothing: empty it rather than topping it up.

Cuttlebone or mineral block

Keep a cuttlebone or mineral block in the cage at all times. It supports calcium intake and gives the beak something appropriate to condition itself against. A budgie's beak never stops growing, and without something to chew it can overgrow and interfere with eating.

LEAVE THESE OUT

Nest-like spaces. Any dark, enclosed hideaway reads as a nest site to a hen and is one of the triggers for chronic egg laying (page 26).

Mirrors. A bird can pair-bond to a mirror or a favorite toy strongly enough to trigger the same reproductive behavior a real mate would.

Zinc or lead. Galvanized hardware, and any metal toy or bell you cannot identify.

Sandpaper perch covers, and round cages.

LINE THE TRAY WITH PLAIN WHITE PAPER

Plain white paper under the grate, changed every day, shows color changes in the droppings that a patterned liner hides, and it keeps droppings out of the bird's reach so they do not dry into dust it breathes.

Temperature, light & sleep

A budgie needs no heater or thermostat. It needs a steady room, the right light, and real darkness.

SETTING	TARGET
Room temperature	About 65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C), with 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C) ideal. Avoid drafts, direct sun and sudden swings. A budgie has no sweat glands and is more heat-sensitive than that range suggests.
Darkness	10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted sleep a night, at about the same clock time every night
UV light	A budgie kept indoors away from unfiltered sunlight needs a full-spectrum UV (ultraviolet) light designed for birds, run 10 to 12 hours a day, inside the day length that leaves the hours of darkness
Sick or recovering bird	75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C); the added warmth stimulates appetite and digestion

Why the dark hours matter

A bird reads day length as a season and uses it to decide when to go into breeding condition. A household that keeps the lights on from before dawn until 10 or 11 at night hands the bird an endless summer. A day longer than 12 hours is a documented risk factor for excessive egg laying, and a budgie hen is one of the small parrots most often seen as an emergency for reproductive disease. Birds under ongoing hormones are also less friendly, more aggressive and more vocal.

Sleep matters for the bird itself, too. Sleep deprivation sits alongside boredom and sexual frustration among the recognized contributors to feather picking, though medical causes still need to be ruled out first.

What counts as uninterrupted

"Uninterrupted" is doing real work. A bird that gets 11 dark hours but has a hallway light flick on twice, or a television glowing across the room, is not getting the same rest as one with 11 genuinely dark, quiet hours.

A timer keeps lights-out consistent when the household's evening is not.

A cover on the main cage blocks light and is a simple support, but it does nothing about a television's sound or people walking through the room. A dedicated sleep cage in a quiet, dark room solves both: a smaller, simple cage with a perch and water, moved there at the same time every night.

HEAT IS THE BIGGER RISK THAN COLD

A budgie is overheating if it pants with its beak open, holds its feathers sleek and flat and holds its wings away from its body. Move it to shade or air conditioning, mist it with room-temperature water, never cold water, and call an avian vet. A bird that lives indoors should spend under 20 minutes in direct sunlight, with shade it can reach.

Air quality: fumes & airborne hazards

A bird's lungs make ordinary household air dangerous. Nothing else in this book has a shorter path from a normal act to a dead bird.

Air moves through a bird's lungs in one direction, pushed along by a system of air sacs that keeps oxygen flowing even on the exhale. That efficiency is the problem indoors: a bird pulls far more air, and far more of whatever is in it, through its lungs than a person in the same room does. The rule of thumb is simple: if you can smell it, it may harm your bird's respiratory tract. A small bird like a budgie goes down faster than a larger parrot on the same exposure, because it has less body mass to buffer it.

Nonstick cookware

PTFE (polytetrafluoroethylene) is the nonstick coating on many pans. Past 280°C (536°F) it breaks down into gases that cause direct, caustic damage to a bird's lungs. An empty pan on a hot burner, or one preheated longer than a recipe calls for, can cross that line in minutes without looking scorched or smelling wrong to a person nearby. Sudden death is often the only sign. When signs do appear they are rapid or labored breathing, wheezing, weakness and seizures. PTFE is not limited to frying pans. Irons, ironing board covers, some self-cleaning ovens and certain heat lamps can carry it. Cook with stainless steel or cast iron, keep the cage out of the kitchen, run the exhaust fan during high-heat cooking, and never run a self-cleaning oven cycle with a bird anywhere in the house.

Anything you can smell

SOURCE	NOTES
Aerosols	Hairspray, spray cleaners, spray deodorants, spray paint. Also carpet fresheners, perfumes and deodorizers.
Candles and wax melts	Votive candles irritate caged birds. Wax melts heat a fragrance compound into the air the same way a lit candle does, so they carry the same risk.
Diffusers and vaporizers	Essential oil diffusers belong in the same "not around your bird" category.
Smoke	Cigarette, cigar and pipe smoke, from direct exposure and from residue that settles on feathers and is preened off later. Cooking smoke and fireplaces matter too.
Melted or burned plastic	Including plastic melted in a microwave.
Carbon monoxide	From any gas appliance. A person cannot detect it until the bird has already reacted. Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in any room with gas heat or a gas range.

IF A SCENT IS STRONG ENOUGH FOR YOU TO NOTICE

Treat it as strong enough to matter for the bird, and move the bird to a well-ventilated room before using the product. Wax melts and newer products are not on older hazard lists, but the mechanism is the same.

A budgie makes far less feather dust than a cockatiel, a cockatoo or an African grey, so dust is not a daily air-quality concern for this species. Cleaning fumes are (page 11).

Metals, pets, plants & everyday traps

The hazards that are not fumes: slow poisons, other animals, and ordinary rooms.

Zinc and lead

Zinc poisoning, sometimes called "new wire disease," comes mainly from galvanized cage hardware. Chewing galvanized wire or metal toys has caused it, because zinc can leach off hot-dipped galvanized coatings without the bird swallowing a visible flake. Electroplated galvanized metal is considered safe; hot-dipped, the more common and cheaper coating, is not. Early signs are stomach upset and appetite loss, then weakness, pale gums and discolored droppings. Powder-coated or stainless steel hardware avoids the problem, and checking a cage's construction before buying beats treating poisoning afterward. Lead works differently and is just as dangerous. Curtain weights, stained glass windows and lamps, costume jewelry and paint in homes built before 1978 are common sources. Lead tastes sweet, which is part of why a bird that finds it keeps chewing. Signs run from weakness and an upset stomach to circling, tremors and leg paralysis, and by then the bird is often seriously ill. Both metals respond to treatment if caught early, so walk the room for galvanized hardware, old paint and vintage glass before a bird has access.

A CAT OR DOG BITE IS A SAME-DAY EMERGENCY

Any mouth contact between a cat or dog and a bird needs a vet the same day, even with no visible wound. Cat saliva carries *Pasteurella* bacteria, which at a bird's body temperature can multiply fast enough to cause fatal blood poisoning within hours of a bite that does not even break the skin visibly through the feathers. A dog's grab adds crushing injury. A vet will typically flush any wound and start antibiotics at once rather than wait for lab results.

Open water, fans, windows and other animals

- **Water.** Most pet birds do not swim well, so an open toilet bowl, a full sink or a pot of hot water is a drowning or scalding risk.
- **Ceiling fans.** A flying bird cannot see spinning blades as an obstacle. A bird flies free only with the fans off.
- **Glass.** Birds generally do not perceive windows and mirrors as barriers and can fly into them hard enough to cause real injury. Open doors and windows are a separate escape risk.
- **Other pets.** Cats, dogs, ferrets and pet reptiles all carry a hunting instinct toward a bird however calm they seem. Out-of-cage time is supervised time, with the other animals out of the room.
- **The room.** Before the cage door opens: ceiling fans off, windows shut, and nothing within reach that a chewing bird can hurt itself on.

Foods and plants within reach

A countertop within flight range of an out-of-cage bird is enough exposure to avocado, chocolate, onion or garlic (the full list is on page 15). A bird that chews leaves out of curiosity cannot tell a safe plant from a toxic one, so check any houseplant against a current toxic-plant list before it comes into a room the bird can reach.

Cleaning & hygiene

The daily health check hides inside the daily chore.

Every day

The paper on the tray is there for daily cleaning, and changing it is also the daily health check: a budgie's droppings are the first place illness shows, so look at them before they go in the bin. It takes thirty seconds.

- Fresh plain paper under the grate, and spot-clean dropped food.
- Every food and water bowl emptied, scrubbed with soap and water and rinsed. Soaking in a disinfectant and rinsing again comes next.
- Replace yesterday's food with one day's fresh portion. Empty the seed dish rather than topping it up.
- Fresh produce comes out within a few hours.

A pair or a small flock soils the paper faster, so check it more often than a single bird needs. A bird that does not bathe on its own should be offered a bath or a misting a few times each week.

The deep clean

A full scrub of the cage follows an order. Every dropping and scrap of food comes off first with detergent, because disinfectant does little against organic debris. Then the disinfectant goes on, and most need 5 to 10 minutes of wet contact to work. Then the cage is rinsed in clean running water, every surface, and left to dry completely before it is put back together.

DISINFECTANT	MIX
Freshly mixed household bleach	1 part bleach to 32 parts water, about half a cup per gallon
Quaternary ammonium disinfectant	Diluted 1 to 1,000, following the label
Any other product	Pet-safe and not an aerosol, following the label

FUMES REACH THE BIRD FAST

The bird waits in a clean cage or travel cage in another room while the cage is scrubbed. The room being cleaned stays ventilated, and no disinfectant is ever mixed with another product. Many disinfectants irritate a bird's airway as much as a person's.

Dust and the people in the house

Dried droppings and feather dust lift into the air when swept. Spray the floor under the cage with water before sweeping, because a vacuum can throw the same particles around. Wooden perches and rope toys cannot be disinfected reliably, so after a sick bird they are thrown out instead of cleaned.

Psittacosis (page 31) can spread from birds to people. Wash your hands with soap and water after handling a bird or its equipment, and between handling one bird and another.

Diet: pellets, seed & grit

Where a lot of budgie care goes wrong, and the biggest lever on how well a budgie lives.

Put a seed mix in front of a budgie and it works the bowl over for the millet, leaves most of the rest, and by the end of the week the dish looks full while the bird has eaten one thing. The trouble with a seed mix is not one missing nutrient. It runs high in fat and carbohydrate, low in protein, and short on vitamins and minerals generally, and selective eating makes the real intake narrower than the label suggests. A seed-only diet is directly linked to malnutrition, obesity and fatty liver disease.

PART OF THE DIET	SHARE	NOTES
Formulated pellets	60 to 80% of daily intake	The base. A pellet packs balanced nutrition into every bite, so the bird cannot skip the parts it needs most.
Vegetables, with a little fruit	20 to 25% at most	Weighted toward vegetables (page 14).
Seed	An occasional extra	Seed stops being the diet. It does not have to disappear entirely.
Millet spray	Small quantities, once or twice a month	The treat that gets overfed.
Grit	None	See below.
Fresh water	Always	Clean, all the time. Wash dishes and bottles daily.

How much a day

The measured part of a budgie's day is the seed. Alongside pellets that are available all day, the seed allowance is about 1 level teaspoon per bird per day. A budgie still eating a seed diet gets 1.5 to 2 level teaspoons a day, in a shallow dish. With more than one bird, each gets its own dish so the bird at the bottom of the pecking order still eats. Seed left in the dish at the end of the day means too much went in, and it is the leftover that lets a budgie eat its millet and skip everything else.

Pellets are not rationed by the spoon. A gram scale shows what the bird really eats: weigh the food going in, weigh what is left 24 hours later, and average the difference over seven days. That average is the bird's real daily intake and the amount to keep offering.

Skip the grit

Grit is sold beside budgie seed and it is one of the few products actively worth avoiding. The logic behind grit applies to birds that swallow seed whole and need help grinding it. A budgie shells the seed and eats the kernel, leaving the husk behind, so grit has no job to do, and a bird that eats it in quantity can end up with a dangerous gastrointestinal obstruction.

THE IODINE PROBLEM

Many seeds are low in iodine, the raw material for thyroid hormone, and budgies are unusually prone to thyroid trouble compared with other pet birds. The result is goiter, which sounds like a breathing noise rather than looking like a swelling (page 31). Formulated diets carry iodine in adequate amounts, which is why the diet itself is the prevention.

Converting a seed eater to pellets

A few weeks of mild inconvenience, if it is done slowly. A real emergency risk, if it is rushed.

NEVER STARVE A BIRD ONTO PELLETS

A bird raised on seed may not recognize a pellet as food, and if the seed disappears before it does, some birds simply go without eating. A budgie should never go more than 12 hours without eating: its fast metabolism leaves a narrow margin.

Two schedules

Both substitute gradually while the bird keeps guaranteed access to the old food. They were written for conures, but the mechanism is the same for any strongly seed-imprinted parrot.

METHOD	STEPS
Stepped	75% seed and 25% pellets for three days, then 50/50 for three days, then 25% seed and 75% pellets until the bird is fully converted.
Tapered	90% seed and 10% pellets on day one, 80/20 on day two, and so on, down to 0% seed on day 10. A bird that balks partway holds at 20% seed and 80% pellets until it converts.

If the bird stalls, hold at that ratio and let the timeline stretch: days, weeks or months are all normal.

What helps with a budgie

- **Offer pellets first thing in the morning**, before any other food, when the bird is hungriest and most willing to try something new.
- **Scatter them on a flat surface** such as a shallow tray rather than a bowl. Foraging across a surface is closer to how a budgie eats anyway, and tapping a fingertip among them gets a hesitant bird started.
- **Use a moist food as a bridge.** Grind pellets to powder and mix it into a small amount of a favorite moist food, such as cooked egg, mashed vegetable or soft fruit, then coarsen the pellet and reduce the moist food over time.
- **Pull the seed only once the bird is eating pellets** alongside fresh vegetables and fruit.
- **Keep a second kind of pellet on hand.** A bird that refuses one for weeks may take another within days.

Check these every day

SIGNAL	NORMAL DURING THE CHANGE	STOP AND CALL A VET
Time without eating	Grazing on and off through the day	12 hours or more
Body weight	Stable, or a small gradual dip	More than 10% below the starting weight. A loss of more than 1 to 2% of body weight in a week means the change is running too fast.
Droppings	Normal size, formed, with a visible fecal part	Minimal, watery or black
Behavior	Curious about the new dish, vocal and active	Puffed, quiet, lethargic or hiding at the bottom of the cage

A wheeze or click during the switch could be stress or goiter. Only a vet exam tells you which.

Vegetables, fruit & fresh food

The 20 to 25% that pellets do not cover, weighted toward vegetables rather than fruit.

Vegetables carry what seed does not, and a budgie introduced to them early takes them far more readily than one meeting them at three years old. The portion is small: a thumbnail-sized amount of any fresh food is the equivalent of a dinner-plate serving for a budgie. It comes out of the cage after a couple of hours, sooner in a warm room, before it spoils.

GROUP	SAFE CHOICES
Vegetables and greens	Asparagus, beet, broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cabbage, carrot, corn, cucumber, dandelion leaves, endive, kale, peppers, pumpkin, romaine, spinach, squash, sweet potato, tomato, zucchini
Fruit, in small pieces	Apple, apricot, banana, blueberry, cantaloupe, cherries with the pit out, dates, figs, grapes, kiwi, mango, melon, orange, papaya, pear, pineapple, raspberry, strawberry
Sprouted grasses	Count as good food, and give a bird something to forage through

CHOOSE BY COLOR

The bright yellow, red and orange foods carry the most vitamin A: bell peppers, broccoli, carrots, sweet potatoes, squash, mango, papaya and cantaloupe. They are the ones worth offering most often.

Little nutrition

Iceberg lettuce is mostly water with little nutritional value, and celery stalks are high in water with few nutrients. Birds like the crunch, but neither earns a regular place, because they displace better food rather than adding anything.

Washing

Birds are very sensitive to pesticides, chemicals and sprays. Wash all produce well and offer organic where you can. Produce from a garden that has been sprayed is off the list.

Getting a suspicious bird to try something new

A budgie that refuses a new vegetable has not decided anything yet. Offer the same fruit or vegetable every day for 3 to 5 days before giving up on it. Scattering food on a flat surface, as in the conversion, works for fresh food too, since it matches how a budgie forages.

The clock

Fresh food goes in when you get up and comes out a couple of hours later. Water needs to be there, clean, all the time. Dishes and bottles want washing daily with soap and water and a thorough rinse, because a dish that has held vegetables and droppings for a day is not somewhere a bird should drink.

Treats, supplements & the never-feed list

The smallest part of the diet, and the part where the real dangers are.

Treats

Millet spray is the treat that gets overfed, because every budgie prefers it to everything else on offer. Small quantities once or twice a month is the allowance. It is also the most useful taming reward there is (page 17), so break a spray into short pieces and count them. Honey sticks are not recommended at all by most avian vets.

Cuttlebone and supplements

A cuttlebone or mineral block belongs in the cage at all times, for calcium and for the beak. A bird eating 75 to 80% of its diet as pellets does not need vitamin supplements. A bird eating mostly seed is the one that does need a proper vitamin and mineral supplement, and any supplement is a vet's decision, not a guess.

NEVER FEED

Avocado. Every part of the plant contains persin, a compound with documented cardiac toxicity in birds, and smaller birds, budgies and canaries specifically, tend to be more sensitive. Respiratory distress typically shows up about 12 hours after eating it, and death is possible within one to two days.

Chocolate. Theobromine and caffeine cause hyperactivity, tremors and potentially seizures. Darker, more bitter chocolate carries more risk.

Caffeine and alcohol, in any amount.

Onion and garlic. They contain chemicals that may harm a bird's blood cells, especially in concentrated forms like garlic powder or dry soup mix.

Very salty food, processed food, and anything cooked with butter or oil.

PITS

Cherries go in with the pit removed. A countertop within flight range of an out-of-cage bird is enough exposure to any of the foods above, so a bird does not need a dramatic accident to be poisoned.

The seed dish trap

A budgie shells its seed and leaves the husks behind, so a dish can look full while holding almost nothing. The tidy-looking, barely touched seed dish is the single most misleading sight in the cage. Empty the husks out before deciding the bird has food, and expect a bird still on seed to need the conversion on page 13 rather than a bigger dish.

Weight, body condition & the daily scale

A budgie hides illness under its feathers. Weight is the vital sign that does not.

A gram scale catches what your eyes and hands cannot. Weight loss shows up on a scale days to weeks before a bird looks visibly thin, sick or fluffed up, because feathers hide body condition extremely well. A bird that finishes its seed dish every day can still be quietly losing body mass, which is exactly how avian gastric yeast works (page 33).

WHAT	TARGET
Typical adult weight	25 to 35 g. Your bird's own settled weight is what matters, because a healthy weight for one frame is not automatically healthy for another.
How often	Every day, at the same time, before breakfast, on the same scale. Write the number down.
Scale	A kitchen scale that reads in grams, not ounces. The swings worth catching in a small bird are often a handful of grams. A perch-style scale a bird can stand on naturally makes the habit easier to keep.
During a diet change	Daily without fail. A loss of more than 1 to 2% in a week means the change is too fast; more than 10% below the starting weight means call the vet.
Obesity	Roughly 20% over the bird's ideal weight, with a body condition score of 4 out of 5

A trend, not a number

A single weight reading tells you almost nothing. A logged trend, taken at the same time of day on the same scale, tells you everything. A vet asking what the bird normally weighs is not making conversation: the difference between 34 g today and 38 g a month ago is a diagnosis, and a bird with no history is a guess. The Owner Log on page 44 is built for it.

Feeling the keel

Weight alone does not say whether that weight is muscle, fat or an empty crop. Body condition scoring in birds is built around one landmark, the keel: the blade-like extension of the breastbone down the center of the chest, where the flight muscles attach on either side. It is assessed by feel, not by eye, because feathers make a visual check nearly useless. The scale runs from 1 (emaciated) to 5 (obese).

WHAT THE FINGER FINDS	WHAT IT POINTS TO
A subtle ridge, with muscle rounded out on either side	Good muscle condition
A sharp, prominent keel with little padding either side	Underweight
A keel you can barely find, cushioned in fat	Overweight

DO NOT CHASE A NUMBER

The value of the keel check is tracking the same bird over time. A keel that has gotten sharper since last month is the signal. The familiar nine-point scale used for dogs and cats does not transfer to birds at all.

Handling & taming

Trust with an animal that can leave. There is no restraint-based version of this.

Where the bird came from sets the pace

A hand-raised budgie is already comfortable with people and may step up on its own from day one. A parent-raised or previously untamed bird needs a slower, more deliberate process, and rushing it sets you back. A young bird from a breeder who has handled it is the easiest to tame; pet store budgies tend to be older and take longer.

Let it settle first

Give a new budgie a week or two to adjust before any taming. Position the cage near eye level and against a wall rather than in an open, exposed spot. If other birds already live in the house, those weeks overlap quarantine (page 24): taming can begin in the separate room once the bird has settled, provided it is handled last each day, after the resident birds.

The progression

Move to the next step only once the bird is calm at the current one.

- 1. **Hand in the cage.** Rest your hand inside, not reaching for the bird, just present, until it stops reacting. A still hand lets the bird decide when to investigate, which matters to a prey species.
- 2. **Millet from your fingers.** Hold a short piece still, close enough that the bird has to approach.
- 3. **Step-up.** Once it takes food from your hand comfortably, gently press a finger against its lower chest and feet area and give the step-up cue.

Speak softly. Sessions are short: one or two a day of five to ten minutes, ended on a success while the bird is still interested.

LATER RUNG	WHAT IT BUYS YOU
Target	The bird touches a stick with its beak on cue, a tool for luring it anywhere without grabbing it
Step up and step down	Handling without a chase; practice the step down as much as the step up
Recall	A bird that comes back on cue, which is what makes a flighted bird manageable
Carrier and towel	A calm bird at every vet visit, and an easy trim or exam

NO DOMINANCE, NO PUNISHMENT

Advice about "establishing dominance" over a bird is outdated and counterproductive. A budgie is a prey animal, and dominance-based handling only teaches it that hands are a threat. Never punish a bite: it teaches fear and undoes hard-won trust.

Hens, bites and stress

Hens can be more territorial than males and tend to bite harder, especially during hormonal periods. That is normal. Frantic flapping, panting or open-mouth breathing, and repeatedly fleeing from your hand all mean stop and try again later. If you must restrain a budgie briefly for medication or a health check, use a small towel rather than bare hands, so the bird associates the unpleasant part with the towel and not with you.

One budgie or two, flock needs & company

A decision that shapes every other one.

Budgies are highly social flock birds. A single budgie needs substantial daily interaction from you to stay well-adjusted, or better, a companion budgie. This is close to as important as diet or cage size. In African grey parrots, living alone (Aydinonat and colleagues, 2014) registered as a long-term physiological stress, not only a behavior problem. A lonely budgie shows it as feather damaging, screaming and biting.

	ONE BUDGIE	A PAIR
Company	You are the flock: daily talking, whistling and hand-taming are the bird's social life.	The bird has a flock-mate. Every bird still needs its own foraging and chewing, and daily time with people.
Talking	Single male budgies tend to be the best talkers.	A budgie is an excellent mimic either way.
Cost	Baseline	The cage, if sized for a pair from the start, stays the same. Food, toys and above all the vet line double, since each bird needs its own exam and tests.
Watch for	Loneliness if the daily time does not happen	A male and a female with any nest site available will breed, and a hen that starts laying is a health problem (page 26).

What the evidence supports

No study has set a number of hours, and the fixed daily figures that circulate do not trace back to research. What holds up is a pattern: daily, predictable contact, especially short training sessions; something to do when alone, such as food hidden around the cage; and a bird that learns to settle by itself. Separation anxiety is the factor tied to feather damaging, so a bird that learns to play alone is better protected.

Adding a second budgie

1. A vet exam for the new bird as soon as it comes home, before the resident is exposed, then 30 to 45 days in a separate room (page 24).
2. Both cages in one room, a distance apart, so the birds get used to the sight and sound of each other. Move them closer over the following days to weeks.
3. The first time together is under strict supervision, and any fighting or bullying means separating them at once.

Some pairs never accept each other. Two budgies that still fight after weeks of side-by-side cages live in separate cages for good, which is a normal outcome and not a failed bird. The two may bond with each other more than with their people: a second bird adds company, not a replacement for daily time with you.

Colonies

Budgies are commonly kept in groups and tolerate it well, and a colony is a different problem from a pair, not a bigger one. No verified space-per-bird or sex-ratio figure exists, so the principles are what count: much more total space than a stack of single-bird cages, more feeding stations than birds, perches at different heights and sightline breaks so no bird controls the whole space, and a single-sex group if you do not want chicks. A mixed-sex group with any nest site is a breeding setup whether you meant one or not. One sick or carrier bird exposes every bird sharing the air.

Body language & normal behavior

Fluffed and content, or fluffed and sick: the distinction that matters most.

A budgie has no crest and no expressive face, so its mood is read from feathers, feet, eyes, beak and voice. No single cue settles the question. The combination does, and the best habit is knowing what your own bird looks like on an ordinary day.

CHECK	FLUFFED AND RELAXED	FLUFFED AND POSSIBLY ILL
Context	After preening, before a nap, first thing in the morning	No obvious trigger, or it lasts through the bird's active time
Duration	Minutes, then the feathers sleek back down	Hours, or most of the day
Feet	One foot, the other tucked into the belly feathers	Standing flat on both feet
Eyes	Open and alert, or briefly closed mid-nap	Stay closed, or slow to open
Activity	Still interested in food, toys and people	Uninterested, quiet, withdrawn
Position	Normal perch height, upright	Low on the perch, or on the cage floor

A bird matching two or three items in the right-hand column, especially both feet down plus sitting low or on the floor, has moved past a normal rest posture and needs an avian vet the same day.

Cues worth knowing

- **Beak grinding** is a soft scraping sound a comfortable bird makes, most often just before it falls asleep. Hearing it is a reasonable sign the bird feels safe.
- **Eye pinning**, the pupils flashing wide and narrow, marks arousal, not a fixed emotion. It shows up around play and excitement and also around aggression, so watch the rest of the bird before putting a hand near its face.
- **Tail fanning** is the tail spreading flat in an excited state, and it settles back down. **Tail bobbing** is a pumping motion timed to each breath: the mark of a bird working harder to breathe, and a same-day vet visit.
- **Head bobbing** can mean impatience to go somewhere, or it comes just before a bird regurgitates onto a favorite person or toy. That is an affection and bonding behavior, distinct from vomiting, which comes with visible distress.
- **One-foot sleeping** is normal. A bird that stops tucking a foot up and stands flat-footed and fluffed through its active hours has moved onto the illness checklist.

BITING IS NOT ONE THING

Biting usually comes from fear, pain, poor handling or a bird testing a boundary. Hens in a hormonal period bite harder (page 26). A bird is more aroused and territorial around a real or imagined nest, so the same hand that was welcome last month can be a target this month.

Noise

A budgie chatters almost constantly at a gentle volume. Most pet birds are loudest at dawn and dusk, a habit that comes from wild contact calling: a bird calls expecting a flock-mate to call back and confirm both are safe. A bird calling for you from another room is running the same program.

Enrichment & common mistakes

The one behavior that fixes several of them: foraging.

Budgies get sold as a starter bird and treated accordingly, with minimal setup and minimal thought. In the wild they spend the bulk of their waking hours foraging, exploring and interacting socially. A cage with a food dish removes almost all of that and gives nothing back, and that gap is where boredom-driven feather plucking and pacing come from.

ENRICHMENT	HOW
Foraging	Hide part of the daily seed or pellet ration in a puzzle feeder or a hanging forage toy, or wrap a small amount of food in paper. Change the hiding method every few days so it stays a puzzle.
Floor feeding	Spread part of the day's pellets thin across a shallow tray on the cage floor, or a flat play-stand top, and let the bird walk through them. Sprouted grasses do the same job.
Chewing	Paper, cardboard and soft wood. Budgies go through them fast, so a rotating supply of cheap items beats one expensive toy. Rotate weekly and replace worn toys monthly.
Flight	An hour of supervised time outside the cage daily, in a room checked for hazards, or time in an enclosed flight cage or aviary
Training	Short sessions on the same positive-reinforcement mechanics that work on any parrot

Research on captive parrots has linked consistent environmental enrichment to reduced feather-plucking behavior, and foraging opportunities specifically are one of the higher-impact changes available.

Common mistakes

THE MISTAKE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
Topping up a seed dish full of husks	Empty it, and convert to pellets (page 13)
A cage bought on price: tall, narrow or round	Buy width, with bars half an inch apart or less
Toys hung in the middle of the cage	Keep the flight path open; toys go around the edges
A hut, nest box or mirror for company	Take it out; it is a laying trigger
The cage in or near the kitchen	Move it today
Lights and television on until late	Protect 10 to 12 hours of dark, quiet sleep
Clipping wings to fix biting or screaming	A trim treats neither; look at the cause
Never weighing the bird	A gram scale is the cheapest diagnostic there is
Waiting to see if it improves	A fluffed budgie on the cage floor has been ill for a while

READING THE WARNING SIGNS

Feather plucking, repetitive pacing along the same stretch of perch, and screaming beyond normal contact calls are the clearest signs that enrichment is not covering current needs. The same signs can flag illness, so check both enrichment and health rather than assuming one.

Flight & wing clipping

You will be asked about this in week one, usually by whoever would do the trim.

The facts are mostly settled: a clip is feathers, not amputation; it grows back at the molt; a correct trim leaves controlled descent; and an incorrect one is dangerous. What is genuinely unsettled is a values call, and it belongs to you and your vet, for this bird and this home.

What a clip is

A clip shortens the primary flight feathers along the outer edge of the wing. The goal is not to stop flight completely but to keep the bird from gaining or holding altitude. A correct trim removes four to seven of the outermost primaries on both wings, cut below the covert feathers that overlay them, with heavier birds needing fewer cut and lighter, more agile ones more. The secondary feathers closer to the body are left alone, because they let the bird slow down and control a landing. Both wings always get the same trim: a one-sided clip leaves the bird lopsided and makes a controlled landing harder. Only mature feathers are cut. A new feather is a blood feather, with a live blood supply running up the shaft. Cutting a mature feather is like a haircut; cutting a blood feather cuts a live vessel. That is the main reason a vet or an experienced groomer should do the first trims.

THE CASE FOR CLIPPING	THE CASE AGAINST
Reduces the risk of flying into windows, mirrors or ceiling fans	Flight is a bird's primary natural exercise, and a safe flighted home can make trimming unnecessary
Lowers the odds of an escape through an open door in a busy household	Loses a major route to cardiovascular and muscular conditioning
Can make early taming manageable for a new or nervous owner	A poor trim risks falls that injure the keel or beak, especially in young birds still learning to fly
Some clipped birds become less brazen and more accepting of hand training	Critics read that same effect as the objection: a bird more accepting of handling because it is less independent has not been trained

What clipping does not do

- **It does not guarantee a bird cannot fly.** A tailwind, a draft, an incomplete trim or feathers that have grown back can all give enough lift to reach an open door.
- **It does not treat behavior.** A bird that bites out of fear before a trim bites out of fear after one, and is just less able to fly away first. Screaming and hormonal behavior have their own causes.
- **It is not permanent.** Every clipped feather regrows at the next molt, and molt is not on a fixed calendar: nutrition, sunlight, day length and humidity all move it. Treat a clip as a decision revisited each molt.

FLIGHTED BIRDS AND A SAFE ROOM

A flighted bird's safety comes down to the same fans, windows and open doors on the hazards page. A bird that reliably returns on cue is a bird that can be out of its cage without every open door being a live risk, which is why recall training makes keeping a bird flighted a realistic option.

Nails, beak, blood feathers & first aid

A budgie weighs a fraction of what a rabbit does, and that changes how much blood it can spare.

Nails

Nails grow continuously, and how fast they need trimming depends more on what the bird stands on all day than on a calendar. Check by looking at the bird in front of you. Every toenail has a blood vessel and nerve running partway down the middle, the quick, and the longer the nail, the further it extends. On a light nail it shows as a pink area; on a dark nail a flashlight held behind it helps. Trim a little at a time. If you cut the quick, keep the bird safely restrained, pinch the toe from side to side just above the cut, then press styptic powder to the nail end, and keep the bird away from its water dish for several hours so the clot is not disturbed.

Beak

AN OVERGROWN BEAK IS A SYMPTOM

A healthy bird with adequate chewing and abrasive surfaces rarely needs a beak trim. An abnormally long beak is most commonly caused by chronic malnutrition or liver disease, and overgrown beak and nails together can point to the liver. A beak that keeps coming back means a vet workup, not another trim.

Broken blood feathers

A blood feather is one still growing in, with an active blood supply through the shaft. A bird carries very little blood for its size, and one that has snapped a blood feather can lose a lot in a short time.

- **Do not pull it at home.** It leaves the shaft open and can cause more blood loss, and even a vet pulls one only as a last resort.
- **Shaft snapped, base still seated:** blot the broken tip and press styptic powder, cornstarch or plain flour onto the exposed end. Never pack powder into an open follicle, which can damage it permanently.
- **Feather torn out completely:** that is an open wound. Use firm, steady pressure with clean gauze and get the bird to a vet.
- **If it has not stopped in two to three minutes,** call an avian vet at once.

A new feather forms in the same follicle and matures in roughly four to six weeks.

The towel

Teach the towel before you need it, in short, reward-paired sessions. In the hold, the head is immobilized with a thumb on one side of the lower beak and a finger on the other, leaving the chest free to move with each breath. Watch the bird, not the task: if its breathing becomes labored or it weakens, return it to the cage at once.

First aid kit

The six items for a small bird's kit, and why each is there, are on the setup checklist (page 36). The most useful one is your avian vet's number.

Choosing a budgie

Most of what makes or breaks a bird-owning household is decided before the bird comes home.

The commitment

A budgie lives 7 to 15 years, which is a shorter commitment than a larger parrot's, not a short one. Match that span to your own life stage and your household's long-term stability, not just to how appealing or affordable the bird is today. Be honest about daily time too: a bird needs real out-of-cage interaction, not just a full dish. The bird itself is the cheap part of owning one (page 38).

Hand-raised or parent-raised

A hand-raised bird is pulled from the nest partway through development and fed by a person. A parent-raised bird stays with its parents through weaning and meets people afterward. Hand-raised birds usually step up more readily, tolerate handling better and bond with people faster. That tameness is not free: Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006), studying African grey parrots, linked hand-rearing to more frustration-related behavior disorders, including aggression and feather picking, and to more dependence on people. Most hand-raised birds live fine lives, and the study was in greys, not budgies. A parent-raised budgie takes longer to tame but starts from a more typical developmental baseline.

Where to get one

SOURCE	ASK
Breeder	To see the parent birds; whether the chick was hand-raised or parent-raised, how old it was when it left the nest, and whether it is weaned; about diet and health issues in their line. Visit in person.
Pet shop	A shop's birds come from several breeders, which mixes health histories. Ask how long the bird has been in the store, whether a vet has examined it, and whether new arrivals are quarantined.
Rescue	A first option, not a fallback. Ask about the bird's history and any known behavior problems before taking it home.

Assessing the bird in front of you

Watch the whole cage before you focus on one bird. A healthy budgie tracks movement, responds to sound, and interacts with its cage mates or surroundings. Its feathers lie smooth and it moves around rather than sitting motionless in a corner. Age shows in the face: full forehead bars and solid dark eyes mean a young bird, which is the easiest to tame.

DO NOT TAKE THIS ONE HOME

A bird that stays fluffed up and still for an extended stretch, sits with its eyes half or fully closed during normal waking hours, ignores activity around the cage, or does not react when you approach and tap gently on the bars is not the bird to take home that day, whatever the price or the selection. If one bird looks off compared with the others, ask the seller what they have seen.

THE VET VISIT IS PART OF THE PURCHASE

A bird can look fine in a cage and still carry something nobody saw. The first exam also gives you a baseline to compare against later.

Quarantine & the first vet visit

A new bird can look completely normal for weeks while carrying something that would spread through a flock in days.

How long, and where

Thirty days is the floor, not a suggestion. It applies to every newly acquired bird, including one that has been to a show, and to a household with no other bird yet. Plan on 30 to 45 days in a separate, isolated room while the bird is screened. For a multi-bird household or aviary, run closer to 90 days, because an infected adult can shed polyomavirus intermittently for up to 90 days.

RULE	WHY
A separate room with its own door, kept shut	Isolation means separate air space, not a second cage in the same room
Its own dishes, perches, toys and cleaning tools	A shared dish, sponge or scoop can carry bacteria or a virus across the gap
Established birds first, the new bird last	Healthy before isolated, every day. Reversed, what is on your hands reaches the birds you are protecting.
Wash your hands between birds	With soap and water, or change gloves. A smock kept for the room helps: dander and droppings travel on clothing.

MEDICINE IS NOT A SHORTCUT

Routine preventive antibiotic treatment is discouraged: it can harm the bird and encourage resistant bacteria. Doxycycline is for a confirmed case of psittacosis (page 31), not for skipping quarantine.

The first exam

It belongs inside quarantine, within one to two weeks of bringing the bird home, so results are back before the new bird meets anyone. Expect a weight, a head-to-tail physical, and then tests chosen from there:

- Blood work: a complete blood count and a chemistry panel.
- A fecal check for intestinal parasites, and a Gram stain for abnormal bacteria or yeast; swabs of the mouth and vent. Whole-body X-rays are sometimes added.
- Screening for psittacosis, polyomavirus, avian bornavirus and PBFD (psittacine beak and feather disease), as the bird's history calls for. A PCR (polymerase chain reaction) test can detect infection in a bird that still looks completely healthy, and because shedding comes and goes, one negative result is not a clean bill of health.
- Two budgie extras worth asking for by name: trichomonas, the parasite behind canker, which is a common cause of death in young budgies, and the yeast behind going light (page 33). Scaly mites, if present, show on the cere and legs during the physical.

Finding the vet

At a minimum, the vet should be a member in good standing of the Association of Avian Veterinarians, whose find-a-vet search lists members by location. Choose one who sees budgies routinely, and ask how many the practice sees. Find the vet before the bird comes home. After the first visit, one checkup a year is the floor and two is the stronger schedule. The first exam costs \$45 to \$65, and tests add to it.

Sexing by cere & the color exceptions

One of the few parrots you can sex by looking, with limits.

The cere is the fleshy patch above the beak where the nostrils sit. In a budgie it is one of the most useful pieces of information a keeper has, for working out sex and for noticing when something is off. In standard-colored birds it works well enough that keepers trust it without DNA testing.

CERE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Blue to purple-blue, a bright deep true blue	A mature male
Tan, brown or pale white; thicker and rougher in breeding condition	A mature female
Pink or pale purple	A juvenile of either sex. Adult color usually settles between 6 and 12 months, so a very young bird cannot be sexed by cere.
Pinkish lavender at any age	Possibly a pastel or solid-color mutation. The cere stays this color for life in those varieties, so the bird could be either sex.

The blue-for-males rule holds for standard blue and standard gray budgies. For anything else, the answer is a DNA test, not another month of waiting. Anyone buying to pair should get that test before trusting a seller's call. Blood is the more accurate sample; a feather is easy to collect at home and mail in.

A hen in breeding condition

A female's cere responding to hormones is normal biology, not a symptom. More daylight, a mate or nesting material can trigger a browner, thicker, sometimes crusty cere that smooths out once she is out of that state.

When a cere change is a warning

Context matters more than the color alone. A brown, crusty cere in a female is usually breeding condition. The same change in a mature male is a different story.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT CAN MEAN
A male's blue fading to brown or tan	Budgies are unusually prone to tumors of the kidney and gonads, and some testicular tumors produce female hormones. The cere can show it over a short period. The reverse happens too, when an ovarian tumor gives a lifelong-brown female a sudden blue cere. Lameness in one leg often travels with these tumors (page 30).
A crusty, porous, honeycombed cere in either sex	Scaly face mites, in the skin of the cere, beak, around the eye, the legs and the vent
A pale or whitish cere	Can go with liver disease or a vitamin A shortfall in the diet
A red, inflamed cere	Infection

SEE AN AVIAN VET

Sudden changes, bleeding, or a change that comes with lethargy or labored breathing are all reasons for a vet visit rather than an assumption that it is hormonal. A tumor's outlook is often poor, which is the case for checking a cere change early.

Hens, hormones & chronic egg laying

A single hen with no male in the house can lay, and repeated laying is what harms her.

A hen does not need a mate or even another bird in the house. Give a single female budgie the right combination of light, food and a spot that feels like a nest, and her body will build and lay eggs on its own schedule, clutch after clutch. Budgerigars, cockatiels and lovebirds are the hens most often seen as emergencies for chronic laying and egg binding.

Typical clutch	4 to 6 eggs on average
Incubation	About 18 days, shorter than the 21 to 28 days quoted for parrots in general

What chronic laying costs her

Each clutch drains the calcium used to build eggshells. The low blood calcium that follows shows as weakness, lethargy, brittle bones that can fracture during normal handling, egg binding, seizures and death. After months or years of laying, the oviduct itself can become diseased and produce abnormal or soft-shelled eggs, and a hen under sustained hormones is often less friendly, more vocal and more aggressive.

The triggers: take away as many as you can

Chronic laying is almost always several triggers stacked together.

- **A long day.** A day over 12 hours is a documented risk factor. Cut it back first (page 8).
- **Abundant, unlimited rich food.** A steady surplus mimics the conditions for raising a wild clutch.
- **A nest box or nest-like site:** a dark enclosed hideaway, a cupboard, a drawer, an unwatched corner of the cage floor.
- **A mate, or something treated as one:** a mirror, a favorite toy, or the owner.
- **Petting.** A hand running down the back toward the tail reads to a hen as a mate's contact. While she is laying, keep touch to the head and neck and shorten sessions.

DO NOT PULL THE CLUTCH

Removing each egg as it appears prompts her to lay more to replace it. Leave her to sit on the eggs for a complete incubation, which for a budgie is about 18 days. At the end, remove the eggs gradually, roughly one every one to two days, rather than all at once, which can restart the cycle the same way. Take away the nest-like furnishings, mirrors and favorite toys at the same time.

Light, diet and the vet

Cutting daylight or room light to 8 hours a day, or 8 to 10 as a short-term measure, can reduce the stimulus to lay. It is a managed intervention to discuss with an avian vet, not a permanent setting, and it takes weeks; the light is lengthened gradually afterward. A pelleted diet with proper calcium is standard advice for a chronic layer, because seed-based diets are short on calcium, selenium and vitamins D and E, and a cuttlebone supports the calcium side.

For a hen that keeps cycling anyway, an avian vet has hormonal options. Leuprolide acetate by injection stops laying for only three to four weeks, so it is repeated on a schedule. A deslorelin implant under the skin lasts three to six months or longer. Neither replaces removing the triggers. A hen that lays heavily, is thin and slow to recover between clutches deserves a vet visit before anything gets stuck.

Egg binding

A hen who cannot pass an egg has hours, not days. This is the page to know by heart.

Egg binding is an egg that forms but fails to pass and lodges in the oviduct. It is the point where chronic laying stops being a management problem and becomes a same-day emergency. Small birds can die within a few hours of becoming egg-bound, as the trapped egg compresses circulation and presses on the air sacs. A hen kept alone can bind, so the risk exists whether or not you breed her. Calcium and vitamin D deficiency and obesity are the links, and diet and light are the prevention.

STAGE	WHAT TO WATCH FOR
Early	Depression, closed eyes, sitting low or on the cage bottom, and no egg passed in 48 hours by a hen that may be laying
Progressing	Weak and not perching, straining as if to lay or defecate, noticeable abdominal swelling
Advanced: act now	A bobbing tail and labored breathing, an egg bulging at the vent or a prolapse, or a hen unable to stand or grip the perch, because the egg presses on the nerves to her legs

WHAT TO DO, IN ORDER

1. Call an avian vet now, the same day and ideally the same hour. There is no home remedy that safely dislodges a bound egg, and waiting for tomorrow's appointment is never the right call.
2. Keep her warm on the way. A sick bird recovers best at 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), so a warm room and a covered carrier are the sensible target. A loose perch or toy comes out of the carrier, and a low, secured perch or a padded floor is safer.
3. Keep food and water within reach. A budgie has almost no energy reserve to spare.

What the vet will do

Mildly affected birds may respond to supplemental heat, injectable fluids, calcium, vitamin D3 and oxytocin, a hormone that makes the oviduct contract and helps push the egg out. In a more severe case the vet may pass a needle through the vent and into the eggshell to draw out the contents, or remove the egg surgically.

Preventing the next one

- A nutritionally complete, pelleted diet, and a cuttlebone or mineral block always available.
- Light limited to 8 hours daily when a hen is cycling, and a quiet, dark sleep every night.
- No nest-like furnishings, no mirror, and no petting down the back.
- Weight kept in check: obesity is one of the predisposing causes.

ONE CLUTCH IS NORMAL

A single unbred hen laying an egg with no male anywhere near surprises many new owners. It is a normal reproductive quirk of the species. It is the repeating that is the medical problem.

Molt & seasonal changes

Normal, uncomfortable, and mistaken for illness often enough to learn.

What a normal molt looks like

Birds normally lose and replace most of their feathers at least once a year, and many also run a smaller partial molt about six months after the main one. Timing is not fixed: nutrition, sunlight, day length and humidity all move it. The defining feature is that it is slow and gradual, and the feathers that come out are whole and undamaged, not shredded or snapped off partway.

New feathers start as pin feathers, growing feathers encased in a waxy sheath that stays soft while the feather is growing and supplied with blood, then dries and flakes away as it matures. Most birds work the dry sheaths loose through ordinary preening. Molting is also demanding: the pin feathers can be uncomfortable, and an otherwise easygoing bird can turn cranky or short-tempered. A bird that suddenly does not want to be handled is usually just having a grumpy molt.

A NORMAL MOLT	PAST A NORMAL MOLT
Slow, with whole, undamaged feathers shed gradually	Bald skin appearing quickly, or feathers that look chewed, pinched or stunted
New pin feathers coming in as old ones drop; no bald skin	Missing patches, or loss from a spot the bird cannot reach, such as the top of its head
Scattered across the body	Loss only where the beak reaches
A quieter, touchier bird	A bird fluffed on the cage floor, off its food, or unwell

Helping through a molt

- **Bathe or mist regularly.** Raised humidity keeps skin from drying out and encourages the preening that works sheaths off. A shallow cage bath left in a few times a week during a heavy molt is a simple way to offer it.
- **Do not pull a pin feather.** A growing one carries a blood supply, and the steps for a broken one are on the grooming page.
- **Expect grumpiness and handle accordingly.** A bird that fusses when you try to help a pin feather that is not ready is behaving normally.

Seasonal changes

Day length is the seasonal signal a budgie reads, and an indoor bird under household lighting can be fooled into breeding condition at any time of year. Expect a browner, thicker cere in a hen and more territorial, cage-protective behavior in a bird in breeding condition. It becomes a problem only when the environment keeps a hen in that state, which is the whole subject of page 26: look at the light before anything else.

Heat is the other season to plan for. A parked car can climb 20°F in 10 minutes and 50°F in an hour, and a bird is never left in one (page 42).

WING FEATHERS GROW BACK AT THE MOLT

A clipped flight feather regrows the next time that feather is molted out, so the molt is also when a trim stops working. Which month that is cannot be predicted from the calendar.

Red flags & finding a vet

A budgie hides illness until it cannot. By the time it looks sick, it has been sick a while.

Birds are prey animals, and hiding illness is a survival instinct that does not switch off in a cage. A budgie that finally looks unwell is usually well into the problem. This page exists to move the moment you notice it earlier, and finding an avian vet before you need one makes a real difference.

SAME DAY: A VET WITHIN 24 HOURS, NOT A FEW DAYS OF WATCHING

Fluffed-up feathers combined with sleeping during the day, particularly standing on both feet.

Tail-bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, or any click, wheeze or change of voice.

Sitting on the floor of the cage instead of perching.

A hen straining, sitting low, or with no egg passed in 48 hours.

Not eating, or droppings stopped or sharply reduced.

Bleeding that has not stopped after two to three minutes of pressure.

Any mouth contact from a cat or dog, even with no wound.

Sudden collapse or a seizure, especially if anything was cooking, spraying or burning in the house.

Within a few days

- Weight trending down over several weighings, or a loss of 10% from the bird's own baseline.
- A change in the droppings that lasts more than 24 hours: color, consistency, number or amount.
- Limping, dragging a leg, a weak grip or falling off the perch, which is often not an injury.
- A cere that has changed color in a mature male, or a crusty, honeycombed cere or beak.
- A new lump anywhere, especially on the chest or belly.
- Abnormal feathers on the head, which a bird cannot do to itself.
- Any change in an established behavior: a chatterer gone quiet, a tame bird refusing to come out.

Normal values worth knowing

Body temperature	About 107°F (41.8°C). Far higher than a mammal's, and not measured at home.
Heart rate	Roughly 274 beats a minute at rest
Breathing	60 to 75 breaths a minute at rest
Weight	25 to 35 g, stable against the bird's own baseline
Droppings	One about every 20 to 30 minutes, with a larger one first thing in the morning

Finding and using a vet

The vet should be an avian vet, at minimum a member in good standing of the Association of Avian Veterinarians, and one who sees budgies routinely. Its find-a-vet search lists members by location. When something is wrong, have ready today's weight and the usual weight, what the bird eats, how long the sign has lasted, and a phone photo of the droppings: a single odd dropping described accurately is far more use than "it looked off yesterday too." Write the vet's number and an after-hours number on the emergency card today, not on the day you need them.

Obesity, fatty liver, lipomas & tumors

The condition group that diet drives, and one that diet does not.

Fatty liver disease and obesity

Driven almost entirely by all-seed diets. Seeds are calorie-dense and nutritionally incomplete, and over time an all-seed diet leads to obesity and hepatic lipidosis, a fatty liver condition serious enough that it can cause sudden death. It is the single biggest preventable health issue in pet budgies. A pellet-forward diet from the start prevents most of it. Obesity means roughly 20% over the bird's ideal weight, a body condition score of 4 out of 5 on the keel (page 16).

An overgrown beak and overgrown nails together can be a sign of liver disease, which is why a beak that keeps growing back needs a vet workup, not another trim.

Lipomas and xanthomas

Benign fatty growths, also linked to high-fat, seed-heavy diets. Budgies are notably prone to tumors compared with many other pet birds, which is another point in favor of a pellet-forward diet. Any new lump is worth a vet visit rather than a guess at home about what kind of lump it is.

Tumors, and the sign nobody expects

Budgies have an unusually high tumor rate for a small bird, and kidney and gonadal (testicular or ovarian) tumors show up often enough to deserve their own explanation.

A LIMP MAY NOT BE AN INJURY

A budgie that suddenly starts limping, drags a leg, grips the perch weakly on one side or falls off its perch is often not injured. Kidney and gonadal tumors sit right next to the nerve that supplies the leg, and a growing mass presses on it. A leg problem can be the first visible sign of a tumor you cannot see from outside the bird.

The pressure on the sciatic nerve (the nerve that supplies the leg) causes lameness in the leg on the affected side, and the leg itself looks completely normal, so it is easy to mistake for a sprain or a fall. Other signs to watch for alongside it include abdominal swelling, general weakness, fluffed feathers, and weight loss even when the bird is still eating normally, since a tumor can grow for a while before appetite drops off. A change in a mature male's cere color is another clue.

Because the mass is not visible from outside, diagnosis needs imaging rather than a hands-on exam alone: usually X-rays to check kidney size and density, sometimes an ultrasound or a look inside the body with a small camera, and blood work. The outlook is not good once a tumor like this is found. There is no surgical option for a mass in this location on a bird this small, and no treatment that cures it, so avian vets shift toward pain control and supportive care aimed at comfort. Getting imaging early does not change that outlook much, but it does rule out the more treatable causes of a limp first.

THE TAKEAWAY

Feed for the liver, weigh for the trend, and treat a limp as a vet visit.

Breathing problems, psittacosis & goiter

Fast-moving, and one of them is catching for people in the house.

Any breathing sign in a budgie is urgent. A bird has very little respiratory reserve, and one that is visibly struggling has often been compensating for days. Tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, a click or wheeze, and a change in the voice are all the same message: a same-day vet visit.

CAUSE	WHAT POINTS TO IT
Infection	Respiratory infections are often secondary to poor air quality or stress
An inhaled toxin	Sudden onset, with nothing else wrong beforehand. Nonstick fumes, aerosols, smoke (page 9).
Goiter	A click, wheeze or squeak on both the in-breath and the out-breath, with no discharge
Psittacosis	Below
Other causes	Egg binding in a hen can show as labored breathing, because the trapped egg presses on the air sacs

Goiter

The thyroid needs iodine to make its hormone, and a bird eating mostly seed runs short. The gland enlarges and, because it sits where the windpipe branches toward each lung, presses on the airway and the voice box. The sound comes from the airway rather than the voice. Other signs can include vomiting and a visibly engorged jugular vein, and a bad case may hold its head up to keep the airway open. It builds slowly: the noise grows louder over months, and a keeper who hears it daily stops noticing. A mild case corrects with supplemental iodine, and a severe one needs a vet, hospitalization and injections. A thyroid tumor can look exactly like goiter; the difference is that goiter resolves quickly once iodine arrives and a tumor does not. The fix is the diet itself.

Psittacosis

Psittacosis, or parrot fever, is caused by the bacterium *Chlamydia psittaci*, and it is zoonotic, meaning it can spread to people. Signs in the bird are respiratory symptoms, diarrhea, weakness and an enlarged liver, and the droppings can turn lime green in both the stool and the urates. Some infected birds look healthy and shed the bacterium only intermittently, which is why a bird that looks clean on day 10 of quarantine can still test positive later.

- **Treatment** is the antibiotic doxycycline for a confirmed case, typically 45 days, or 30 days for a budgerigar.
- **If you suspect it**, mention the possibility to your vet directly, and keep any newly introduced bird separate from the rest of your flock.
- **For people**, cleaning a cage is the exposure. Spray surfaces with water before sweeping so dried droppings do not lift into the air, and wash your hands after handling birds or equipment.

WHILE YOU GET TO THE VET

Keep the bird warm, around 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), keep food and water within reach, and stop any spraying, cooking or cleaning in the house. If a toxin is suspected, get the bird into fresh air first and call from outside.

Polyomavirus, French molt & beak and feather disease

Two viruses that both leave a bird with feathers that look wrong, and the budgie is the species the first one is named for.

Avian polyomavirus

This virus causes disease in young parrots, and in budgies it is called budgerigar fledgling disease. It is two diseases wearing one name, and the gap between them is mostly the bird's age at infection.

- **Unweaned chicks:** signs appear 7 to 10 days after exposure: lethargy, and a crop that stops emptying. Death follows within 24 to 48 hours. Mortality can reach 100% in birds under 15 days old, and many juveniles die quickly with no signs at all.
- **Survivors older than three weeks** often develop feather dystrophy, known as French molt or feather dusters. Down feathers around the head and neck grow poorly, and the contour and flight feathers are abnormal. A bird with stubby or missing flight feathers that cannot fly is sometimes called a runner. It keeps that abnormal feathering rather than replacing it with a normal coat.

Adult birds are typically resistant to the disease itself but can shed the virus for up to 90 days before clearing it, with no signs. A bird that has recovered can remain a carrier. The virus travels in feather dust, droppings, urine and secretions, and budgerigars have one route no other affected species has: passing from an infected parent straight into the egg. That is why a clean-looking breeding pair is not proof of anything, and why a new bird goes through full quarantine (page 24).

A vaccine exists for selected parrots. Its documented schedule for chicks starts after 35 days of age with a booster 2 to 3 weeks later, and breeding birds get two doses two weeks apart in the off-season. That 35-day start was documented in cockatiels and Quaker parakeets, not budgie chicks, so the schedule for a given bird is a vet's decision and a fair question to ask a breeder.

Psittacine beak and feather disease

PBFD (psittacine beak and feather disease) is caused by a circovirus that attacks the fast-growing skin cells behind the beak and the feather follicles, so both grow visibly wrong. It occurs mainly in parrots native to Africa, Australia, New Zealand and Indonesia. Feathers look stunted, club-shaped or pinched off, changing symmetrically across the body; the beak can grow long, flaky or oddly shiny; and feathers are lost even where the bird cannot reach. It can occur at any age but is most common in birds under three. There is no cure and no vaccine, and most affected birds eventually die of secondary infections. It spreads in feather dust, dander and droppings.

	POLYOMAVIRUS (FRENCH MOLT)	PBFD
Virus family	Polyomaviridae	Circovirus
Hits hardest	Unweaned budgie chicks	Any age, most often under three years
Feathers	Dystrophy in survivors older than three weeks	Stunted, club-shaped or pinched, symmetrical
Vaccine	Exists for selected parrots	None, and no cure

DO NOT GUESS FROM A PHOTO

The two look alike and call for different handling. An avian vet can test for polyomavirus directly and can test for PBFD with a PCR (polymerase chain reaction) test on feces, feather dander or blood.

Scaly face mites, canker & avian gastric yeast

Three conditions this species gets more than most, and the first two are treatable.

Scaly face and leg mites

Caused by the mite *Knemidocoptes pilae*. Look for crusty, honeycomb-like buildup on the cere, the beak and the legs, and sometimes around the eyes and the vent. It is treatable with ivermectin from an avian vet, but it needs a proper diagnosis rather than a home remedy.

Trichomonas (canker)

Trichomonas is the parasite behind canker. It causes vomiting, sticky head feathers and crop swelling, and it is a common cause of death in young budgies. Some avian practices test every new budgie for it as routine, so ask for it at the first exam.

Avian gastric yeast, the "going light" disease

Avian gastric yeast, once called megabacteriosis, is a yeast, *Macrorhabdus ornithogaster*, not a bacterium. It sits where the true stomach meets the muscular gizzard and disrupts the acid environment a bird needs to digest. Budgerigars, parrotlets, lovebirds, cockatiels and finches are the small pet birds most often affected, and budgies carry the longest history with it. The term "going light" for a chronic wasting pattern comes from decades of watching this exact picture.

EATING NORMALLY AND LOSING WEIGHT

A bird with this yeast can keep eating on schedule, sometimes even eating more, and still lose ground by the gram, because it digests less of what it swallows. Other signs are regurgitation, lethargy, diarrhea, and undigested seed passed whole in the droppings. The only reliable early catch is the daily gram scale. An uncommon acute form has been documented in budgerigars in otherwise good condition that collapse and die within 12 to 24 hours, usually from bleeding inside the stomach, so any of these signs plus sudden weakness is a same-day visit.

- **Diagnosis** is a fresh dropping examined under a microscope, sometimes with a stain, and PCR at some laboratories. The yeast sheds on and off, so one negative result does not clear a bird, and a vet may want droppings checked on more than one day.
- **Outlook** varies widely: mortality runs from 10 to 80% of affected birds, depending on the bird's condition and the strain.
- **Treatment** is oral amphotericin B twice a day for a minimum of 30 days, the protocol with the highest success rate. Failures are common when the course is shorter, and the most common reason is stopping early because the bird looks better. Expect a recheck fecal exam during the course and another after it ends, because a bird can look recovered while still shedding.
- **Reducing risk:** the yeast shows up alongside stress and immune suppression. Quarantine and fecal-check every new bird, keep cages and dishes genuinely clean, and weigh daily.

Feather plucking & feather loss

Rule out the medical causes first. Most owners work this list backwards.

A bird missing feathers sends most owners straight to the scariest answer. Before anything else, compare what you see against a normal molt (page 28), then use the one built-in physical limit of plucking: a bird can only chew, pull or over-preen feathers its own beak can reach.

	WHAT THE FEATHERS LOOK LIKE	WHERE	FIRST MOVE
Normal molt	Whole feathers shed gradually, new pins coming in	Scattered across the body	Bathe or mist; let it run
Plucking	Chewed at the skin, ragged tips, or pulled out	Only where the bird can reach; the head is spared	Vet visit to rule out a medical cause, then environment and behavior
PBFD	Stunted, club-shaped or pinched, changing symmetrically; beak flaky or overgrown	Includes places the bird cannot reach	Avian vet diagnosis; no cure
Polyomavirus (French molt)	Dystrophic flight and tail feathers in a young bird	Wing and tail; down on the head and neck	Avian vet diagnosis

THE HEAD TELLS YOU

A bird with bald or damaged feathers on its chest, back or under its wings but a full set on top of its head is very likely doing it to itself. A bird losing feathers from the top of its head while everything else looks fine is not plucking, because it cannot reach that spot. A bird preening a partner's head, or scratching its own on a cage bar, is doing normal maintenance.

Work the list in this order

1. **Is it plucking at all?** Use the table above.
2. **Medical.** Skin inflammation or infection, wider disease, cancer, malnutrition and toxins can all produce the same picture, and environmental changes only help once those are treated or ruled out. A vet visit is step two, not step ten.
3. **Sleep.** Sleep deprivation sits alongside boredom and sexual frustration among the recognized contributors. Protect 10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness (page 8).
4. **Hormones.** Sustained hormonal stimulation brings territorial aggression, screaming and feather-destructive behavior.
5. **Foraging and company.** Restore foraging, increase out-of-cage time, and address loneliness honestly (page 18).

How common is it in budgies?

In a Japanese survey of 2,331 pet parrots (Ebisawa and colleagues, 2021), 11.7% showed feather-damaging behavior, but only 4.9% of budgerigars did, against 30.6% of cockatoos. Adults were about three times as likely as juveniles to do it, and birds showing signs of separation anxiety had 1.81 times the odds. Hours spent alone and having a cage mate did not independently predict it once species and age were counted, so the quality of the bird's relationship with its people appears to matter more than a count of hours. Plucking in a budgie still deserves a proper look rather than another toy.

Reading droppings & water

The one health check that costs nothing and happens by itself every 20 to 30 minutes.

A normal dropping is three separate outputs mixed together, because a bird's digestive, urinary and reproductive tracts all empty into one compartment and leave through one shared opening, the vent. The **feces** are the solid, formed part, green or brown. The **urates** are the white or cream, chalky part: uric acid, the solid form of urine, which lets a bird excrete nitrogen while conserving water. The **urine** is the clear liquid that rings the rest of the dropping.

PART	NORMAL	GENUINE RED FLAG
Feces	Green to brown, shifting with diet, sometimes red or orange on colored pellets	Black or tarry, bright red or blood-tinged, or watery with no formed stool
Urates	White to cream	Bright yellow or lime green, especially if the stool turns lime green too
Urine	Clear, a small ring	Large volumes of clear liquid on every dropping, or a marked drop in how often the bird goes
Texture	Solid, curled, holds its shape	Undigested whole seed, pea-soup consistency, or bubbles

What the red flags can mean

- **Lime-green urates and stool** together point to psittacosis (page 31), a common cause of liver disease in birds.
- **Undigested seed or pellets** in the droppings can mean avian gastric yeast, which damages the stomach enough to block digestion even while the bird keeps eating (page 33).
- **Bloody urine** turning droppings red or black can mean lead poisoning (page 10).

Polyuria is not diarrhea

Polyuria is extra clear liquid around an otherwise normal, formed stool. If the solid part is still there and still shaped, it is excess urine, commonly triggered by stress, a diet change, or a lot of watery food like fresh fruit, and on its own it is usually not an emergency. **True diarrhea** is the fecal part itself turning mushy or semi-liquid, with no formed stool left, and it shows up alongside several serious conditions. One wrinkle: polyuria without an obvious dietary cause can be the first sign of kidney disease from zinc poisoning.

THE 24-HOUR RULE

Once you know your bird's normal, any deviation counts, and if it lasts longer than 24 hours it is a same-day call to an avian vet. Call sooner for blood in a dropping, black or tarry droppings, a bird that has stopped producing droppings anywhere near its normal frequency, or any change paired with a fluffed-up, quiet or off-food bird.

Building the habit, and water

Line the tray with plain white paper, swap it daily, and glance at it at the same time. Note anything unusual with a date, even as a phone photo. Water must be there, clean, all the time, in a dish washed daily.

Setup checklist & targets

Print this one. Audit an existing setup against it, or buy against it.

The cage

- ☐ At least 18×18×18 in (46×46×46 cm); about 30×18×18 in (76×46×46 cm) for a pair
- ☐ Bars half an inch (1.3 cm) apart or closer; not round
- ☐ Stainless or powder-coated; no zinc or lead in the finish (page 10)
- ☐ Against a wall, at or near eye level, off drafts and out of direct sun
- ☐ Not in or next to the kitchen
- ☐ Cover or a quiet sleep cage for 10 to 12 hours of darkness
- ☐ Plain white paper on the tray, changed daily
- ☐ Full-spectrum UV light made for birds, if no unfiltered sunlight (page 8)

Diet and equipment

- ☐ Pellets 60 to 80% of the diet; vegetables with a little fruit 20 to 25%
- ☐ Seed about 1 level teaspoon a day; millet in small quantities, once or twice a month
- ☐ Fresh water, dishes washed daily

First aid kit

- ☐ Styptic powder (cornstarch or flour as a backup)
- ☐ Small nail clippers
- ☐ Clean gauze squares

Inside the cage

- ☐ Perches of varied diameter, texture and material
- ☐ Dishes away from perches, at opposite ends from each other
- ☐ Cuttlebone or mineral block, always available
- ☐ Toys around the edges, a clear flight path, chewable items rotating
- ☐ A foraging feeder or paper wrap in daily use
- ☐ No nest-like hideaway, no mirror, no sandpaper perch cover
- ☐ No grit

- ☐ Gram scale reading in single grams; weigh daily
- ☐ Travel carrier and first aid kit ready
- ☐ Avian vet found; number on the emergency card
- ☐ Nonstick cookware replaced, aerosols and scented products out of the bird's air

- ☐ A small hand towel kept for this
- ☐ A small flashlight or phone light
- ☐ Avian vet and emergency clinic numbers

Targets at a glance

Room temperature	65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C), ideal 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C); no drafts, no sudden swings
Darkness	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, at the same clock time every night
Weight	25 to 35 g, stable against the bird's own baseline; weighed every day
Out-of-cage time	An hour a day, supervised, in a room checked for hazards
Vet	A first exam within 1 to 2 weeks, then a checkup at least once a year, twice is better

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AVIAN VET NOW IF

The bird is on the cage floor, fluffed, or sleeping in the day · tail bobbing with each breath, or open-mouth breathing · bleeding that does not stop in two to three minutes · not eating, or droppings stopped · a hen straining, sitting low, or no egg passed in 48 hours · any mouth contact from a cat or dog · collapse, a seizure, or a suspected fume exposure (fresh air first) · a sudden limp or a foot that will not grip.

TARGET	VALUE
Cage and bars	At least 18×18×18 in (46 cm) for one bird, about 30×18×18 in (76×46×46 cm) for a pair; bars half an inch (1.3 cm) or closer
Room temperature	65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C); ideal 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C)
Sick or recovering bird	75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C)
Darkness	10 to 12 hours; 8 hours of light is the managed step to break a laying cycle, with a vet
Diet	60 to 80% pellets, 20 to 25% vegetables and a little fruit, seed the remainder
Weight	25 to 35 g. Call the vet at a 10% drop from the baseline; never more than 12 hours without eating.
Quarantine, new bird	30 to 45 days in a separate room; nearer 90 for a multi-bird household
Nonstick danger point	280°C (536°F), reached by an empty pan in minutes

Your numbers

Avian vet _____ Baseline weight (g) _____
 24-hour emergency clinic _____ Last vet visit _____
 Bird's name and hatch date _____ Next due _____

GETTING THERE

Use a stripped-down carrier, belted into the back seat away from an active airbag, partly covered. Skip the water dish, which spills under braking; offer a slice of fruit or a leafy green. Keep the bird warm, and never leave it in a parked car (page 42). Bring the weights, a droppings photo and the diet.

Budget & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked in September 2026. Treat them as a snapshot, not a quote.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
The bird itself	\$20 to \$80
Cage (a wide flight-style cage)	\$100 to \$300
Perches	\$15 to \$25
Food and water dishes	\$10 to \$20
Toys: swings, ladders, foraging	\$20 to \$40
Complete starter setup, bird included	\$165 to \$465
First avian vet exam, within the first one to two weeks	\$45 to \$65

MONTHLY ONGOING, ONE BIRD	TYPICAL COST
Food: pellets with fresh vegetables	\$5 to \$30
Toy and perch replacement	\$10 to \$20
Annual well-bird exam, averaged	about \$4 to \$5
Added up	about \$19 to \$55

FIRST YEAR, BIRD INCLUDED	TOTAL
Floor: \$165 setup, \$15 a month for food and toys, one \$45 exam	about \$390
Ceiling: \$465 setup, \$50 a month, one \$65 exam	about \$1,130

PLAN FOR, DO NOT COUNT ON AVOIDING

A twice-yearly checkup is \$90 to \$130 a year before tests. Diagnostics such as a fecal exam, a Gram stain or blood work add to each visit, an emergency exam is \$50 to \$75 before treatment, and emergency treatment or surgery runs \$100 to \$1,500 or more. Set aside a dedicated emergency fund.

NOT PRICED IN THE TABLE

A full-spectrum UV light made for birds, a gram scale, a travel carrier, a cage cover or sleep cage, a cuttlebone, the first bag of pellets and a first aid kit are all worth buying and none is in the setup range above. A second budgie shares the cage but doubles food, toys and the vet line.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The cage: a too-small one becomes a welfare problem, not just a maintenance one. Spend on width, bar spacing and finish, and save on toys, which are paper and soft wood.

First 30 days

In order. Most of week one is doing less than you want to.

Before the bird arrives

- ☐ Cage built, stocked and sited before pickup day (page 6)
- ☐ Avian vet found and the number written down (page 24)
- ☐ Quarantine room ready if you already keep birds
- ☐ Nonstick cookware replaced, aerosols and candles moved out (page 9)
- ☐ Gram scale, carrier and first aid kit bought
- ☐ Pellets, vegetables and a cuttlebone in the house

Days 1 to 7: let it settle

- ☐ Cage at eye level against a wall. Food, water and cleaning only; no taming yet
- ☐ Look at the droppings every morning; they are the first thing to go odd (page 35)
- ☐ Start the sleep routine on day one: 10 to 12 hours of dark, the same time nightly (page 8)
- ☐ Weigh before breakfast every day and write the number down (page 16)

Days 8 to 14

- ☐ First avian exam, within one to two weeks of arrival, whether or not anything looks wrong
- ☐ Hand resting in the cage, doing nothing, in short sessions (page 17)
- ☐ Offer the same vegetable daily for 3 to 5 days before giving up on it (page 14)
- ☐ Add a foraging feeder alongside the normal dish, then move part of the ration into it

Days 15 to 30

- ☐ If the bird came on seed, begin the pellet conversion, weighing daily (page 13)
- ☐ Millet in short pieces from your fingers, then the step-up cue once food is taken calmly
- ☐ Check one room for hazards and take the first out-of-cage session there (page 10)
- ☐ Rotate the toys weekly; replace worn ones monthly (page 20)
- ☐ End of quarantine at 30 to 45 days, if you keep other birds; then the introduction stages (page 18)

WHAT NORMAL LOOKS LIKE BY DAY 30

Eating and drinking, droppings consistent, chattering, preening, sleeping on one foot, and grinding its beak quietly at bedtime, which is contentment.

Symptom quick reference

What you see, what it might be, and how fast to move. A budgie that has visibly changed has been unwell a while, so when in doubt, call.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MIGHT BE	ACT
On the cage floor, fluffed	Serious illness of almost any kind; egg binding in a hen (page 27)	Same day
Tail bobbing with each breath; open-mouth breathing	Breathing effort: infection, an inhaled toxin, egg binding (page 31)	Same day
Click, wheeze or squeak on both breaths	Goiter from iodine deficiency; infection	Same day
Collapse or seizure	Nonstick or aerosol fumes, heavy metal (page 9)	Now; fresh air first
Straining, sitting low, no egg in 48 hours	Egg binding	Now
Bleeding	Broken blood feather, nail, cage injury (page 22)	Pressure; vet if not stopped in 2 to 3 minutes
Mouth contact from a cat or dog	Fatal blood poisoning from <i>Pasteurella</i> , even with no wound	Same day
Limp, dragging a leg, weak grip	Kidney or gonadal tumor pressing on the nerve; injury (page 30)	Vet soon
Eating well but losing weight; whole seed in droppings	Avian gastric yeast (page 33)	Vet soon
Lime-green or bright yellow urates	Liver disease; psittacosis	Vet soon
Black, tarry or bloody droppings	Bleeding; lead	Same day
Watery droppings, solid part formed; or a mushy fecal part	Polyuria (stress, a diet change, watery food, or kidney disease with no obvious cause) or true diarrhea (page 35)	Call after 24 hours
Vomiting, sticky head feathers, swollen crop	Trichomonas (canker)	Vet soon
Crusty, honeycombed cere, beak or legs	Scaly face and leg mites	Vet soon
A male's cere turning brown or tan	Tumor making female hormones. Normal breeding condition in a hen (page 25).	Vet soon
Overgrown beak or nails	Liver disease, mites, malnutrition. Not a grooming problem.	Vet workup
A new lump	Lipoma, xanthoma or a tumor	Vet soon
Feathers missing, head spared	Plucking. Rule out medical causes first (page 34).	Vet, then environment
Feathers abnormal or missing on the head	Not self-inflicted: PBFD or polyomavirus (page 32)	Vet soon
Symmetrical loss with pin feathers coming in	Normal molt (page 28)	Monitor
Regurgitating onto a toy or mirror	An affection and bonding behavior, and a hormonal signal	Remove the object
A chatterer gone quiet	Any illness: a change in a habit is a symptom	Vet soon

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Ten minutes of care, an hour of company, and a few jobs that keep the rest working.

Every day

- ☐ Weigh before breakfast; log it (page 16)
- ☐ Change the paper; read the droppings (page 35)
- ☐ Fresh water; wash the bowls
- ☐ Empty the seed husks; one day's seed in a shallow dish
- ☐ Fresh pellets; vegetables in, and out again after a couple of hours
- ☐ Look at the bird properly: posture, breathing, feathers, both feet gripping
- ☐ An hour out of the cage in a checked room, and a short training session
- ☐ Cover the cage or move to the sleep cage at the same hour

Every week

- ☐ Rotate the toys; hide food a new way
- ☐ Offer a bath or misting a few times
- ☐ Look at nails, cere and beak

Every month

- ☐ Replace worn toys
- ☐ Deep clean the cage, with the bird in another room (page 11)
- ☐ Review the weight log as a trend
- ☐ Re-check the room: new candles, sprays and cookware arrive quietly (page 9)

Every year

- ☐ Wellness exam, twice if you can; replace worn perches

Seasonal

WHEN	WHAT CHANGES
Long days, spring and summer	Longer days push birds toward breeding condition. Hold the indoor light schedule steady and watch hens for laying behavior (page 26).
Hot weather	A caged bird cannot leave the sun, so check for a moving sunbeam. Offer baths, keep the bird in shade, and never leave it in a closed car (page 42).
Molt	A bird is quieter and touchier. Bathe or mist more, feed well and handle less (page 28).
Cold weather and outages	No candles, kerosene or propane heaters, or gas oven for warmth. Cover the cage and move it to the warmest interior room.

Power outages, heat, travel & transport

For a bird, the danger in a blackout is usually what people light, not the cold.

THE OPPOSITE OF THE REPTILE PLAN

A budgie is warm-blooded and carries almost no fat between meals. During an outage, keep food and water in front of it the whole time, checked and refilled by hand if anything depends on power. A bird that goes off food during a stressful outage is a reason to call the vet, not to pull the bowl.

During an outage

- No candles, no kerosene or propane heater, no gas stove or oven as a heater, in any room the bird is in. Flashlights and battery candles beat open flame.
- A generator runs outside, at least 20 feet (about 6 meters) from doors, windows and vents, and never in or near a garage, house or shed. An open window is not enough.
- Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in any room with gas heat, a gas range or a nearby generator. People need levels above about 70 parts per million before they feel anything, and a bird has no such buffer.
- For warmth, cover most of the cage with a thick towel or blanket, leaving a gap for airflow, and move it to the warmest interior room, away from exterior walls and windows. A wrapped hot water bottle goes near the cage, never touching it.

Hot weather

A bird indoors should spend under 20 minutes in direct sunlight, with shade it can reach. An overheating bird pants with its beak open, feathers sleek and flat, wings held away from its body. Fluffed feathers are the opposite signal: cold or sick. Move it to shade or air conditioning, mist it with room-temperature water, never cold, and call an avian vet on the way.

Travel and the carrier

	WHAT TO DO
The carrier, not the cage	A compact carrier with a low, secured perch or a padded floor, belted in or strapped, in the back seat away from an active airbag. A full cage's shape and dish placement do not secure well.
Stress and water	Cover part of the carrier with a light, breathable cloth, and keep one side open for air. Loose toys and swings come out before a trip. Skip the water dish for the drive and offer a slice of fruit or a leafy green.
Never a parked car	A cabin can climb 20°F in 10 minutes and 50°F in an hour, so a 75°F day puts it near 95°F by the time a quick stop becomes a checkout line. In cold weather it chills just as fast. The bird comes in with you.
Direct sun	A carrier on a sunny seat offers no shade at all. Keep it out of direct sun through the windows.

WRITE IT DOWN BEFORE THE POWER GOES OUT

The vet's number and the nearest 24-hour exotics clinic belong on the emergency card and on the sitter sheet, not in your head.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE CAGE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through a real feeding and cage check before the first solo visit.

Bird's name _____

Avian vet _____

Cock or hen; normal weight (g) _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Every day: feeding comes first

A missed meal is not acceptable "just this once": a budgie has almost no reserve.

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Fresh water; wash the bowls, do not just top up. | ☐ Change the paper on the tray. Glance at the droppings first: a green or brown coil, white urates, a little clear liquid. |
| ☐ Pellets: _____ a day, kept at _____. | ☐ Room temperature should stay 65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C). |
| ☐ Seed: 1 level teaspoon at most, in a shallow dish. Tip out the husks first. | ☐ Cover the cage at _____ and uncover at _____, for 10 to 12 hours of dark and quiet. |
| ☐ Vegetables in the morning: _____ Take them out after a couple of hours. | ☐ Talk to the bird. Ten minutes near the cage counts. |

Please don't

- Use a candle, space heater, nonstick pan, aerosol or scented product anywhere near the bird's room.
- Let the bird out of the cage, or let another animal into the room.
- Introduce new toys or foods without asking. Never feed avocado, chocolate, onion, garlic, caffeine, alcohol or anything salty.

CALL ME, OR THE VET, IF

The bird stops eating entirely · sits fluffed and unresponsive, or on the floor of the cage · breathes with an open beak or its tail bobs with each breath · there are no droppings, or far fewer · there is blood anywhere · the power or heat goes out and cannot be restored quickly. If you cannot reach me, call the vet number above.

Where the pellets and cleaning things are _____

Anything else _____

Weight is the vital sign that moves before anything else is visible. Write the number even when it is boring: the boring numbers are what make one interesting number readable. A vet asking what the bird normally weighs is diagnosing, not chatting. Take this page to the visit.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	REPLACED	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Perches			
Cuttlebone or mineral block			
UV light			
Pellet bag opened			
Cage cover			

First aid kit checked (twice a year)

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Month 1 is whichever month you start in.

TASK, BY MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Weight trend reviewed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Room hazard re-check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Wellness exam	☐					☐						☐
Perches checked and replaced			☐						☐			

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS	TREATMENT AND FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Perches of varied width and texture, at opposite ends of the cage
- ☐ Dishes at opposite ends too, so eating and drinking take a flight
- ☐ Toys around the edges, with the flight path open
- ☐ A cuttlebone or mineral block
- ☐ Part of the daily ration hidden, wrapped in paper, or in a forage toy (page 20)

Each week

- ☐ Rotate the toys; change the way food is hidden
- ☐ Scatter part of the pellets on a shallow tray
- ☐ Offer paper, cardboard or soft wood to destroy
- ☐ Offer a bath or misting a few times
- ☐ Short training sessions, five to ten minutes (page 17)
- ☐ An hour out of the cage each day, in a checked room

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

IF THE SAME BEHAVIOR KEEPS SHOWING UP

Feather plucking, pacing and unusual screaming mean enrichment is not covering current needs, or that the bird is unwell. Check both.

Glossary, A to L

Avian bornavirus	A virus screened for at the first vet exam, along with psittacosis, polyomavirus and PBFD. Page 24.
Avian gastric yeast	A yeast (<i>Macrorhabdus ornithogaster</i>), once called megabacteriosis, that disrupts digestion. The classic cause of "going light": a budgie eating well and losing weight. Page 33.
Avian polyomavirus	A virus that kills unweaned chicks and leaves survivors with French molt. Called budgerigar fledgling disease in budgies. Page 32.
Bar spacing	The gap between cage bars: half an inch (1.3 cm) or less for a budgie. A head-entrapment and escape limit. Page 6.
Blood feather	A feather still growing, with a blood supply running up the shaft. Breaking one can bleed heavily in a bird this small. Page 22.
Canker	The disease caused by the trichomonas parasite: vomiting, sticky head feathers and a swollen crop. Page 33.
Cere	The fleshy patch above the beak where the nostrils sit. Its color shows sex, age and sometimes illness. Page 25.
Circovirus	The family of virus behind PBFD. Page 32.
Clutch	The eggs a hen lays in one run: 4 to 6 on average for a budgie. Page 26.
Contact call	A call a bird makes expecting a flock-mate to call back and confirm both are safe. The root of noise at dawn and dusk. Page 19.
Crop	The pouch at the base of a bird's neck where food is held. A crop that stops emptying is a serious sign. Page 32.
Cuttlebone	The calcium-rich internal shell of a cuttlefish, kept in the cage for calcium and for the beak to wear against. Page 7.
DNA	Deoxyribonucleic acid: the genetic code. A DNA test on a blood sample or a feather sexes a bird whatever its color or age. Page 25.
Doxycycline	The antibiotic used to treat a confirmed case of psittacosis, for 45 days, or 30 in a budgerigar. Page 31.
Egg binding	A formed egg the hen cannot pass. A same-day emergency. Page 27.
Fecal check	A vet's microscope check of a dropping for parasites and yeast. Pages 24, 33.
French molt	The chronic feather form of polyomavirus in budgies: abnormal flight and tail feathers, often a bird that cannot fly. Also called feather dusters. Page 32.
Goiter	An enlarged thyroid, from too little iodine in a seed diet. It sounds like a breathing noise, not a swelling. Page 31.
Gram stain	A lab stain that shows abnormal bacteria or yeast in a swab or dropping. Page 24.
Hand-raised	Pulled from the nest and fed by a person. Usually tamer, and more dependent on people. Page 23.
Hepatic lipidosis	Fatty liver disease: fat building up in the liver, most often from an all-seed diet. Page 30.
Hypocalcemia	Low blood calcium. Chronic laying drains calcium into eggshells and can cause weakness, fractures and seizures. Page 26.
Keel	The blade of breastbone down the center of the chest. Felt, not seen, to score body condition. Page 16.
<i>Knemidocoptes pilae</i>	The mite that causes scaly face and scaly leg. Page 33.
Leuprolide acetate	A hormone drug given by injection to stop laying for three to four weeks. Prescribed by an avian vet. Page 26.
Lipoma	A benign fatty growth, linked to high-fat, seed-heavy diets. Page 30.

Glossary, M to Z

Molt	The gradual replacement of feathers, at least once a year. Slow, with whole feathers and no bald skin. Page 28.
Neoplasia	Tumors. Budgies have an unusually high rate, mostly of the kidney and gonads. Page 30.
Oviduct	The tube an egg travels down. It can become diseased after months of chronic laying. Page 26.
<i>Pasteurella</i>	Bacteria in cat saliva that can cause fatal blood poisoning in a bitten bird within hours. Page 10.
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease: a circovirus that stunts feathers and damages the beak. No cure and no vaccine. Page 32.
PCR	Polymerase chain reaction: a lab test that detects a germ's genetic material, even in a bird that looks healthy. Pages 24, 32.
Pellets	A formulated food that packs balanced nutrition into every bite. The base of the diet at 60 to 80%. Page 12.
Photoperiod	Hours of light per day. A day over 12 hours is a risk factor for chronic laying. Page 8.
Pin feather	A new feather in its waxy sheath. Tender, and worked loose by preening. Page 28.
Polyuria	Extra clear liquid urine with the solid fecal part still formed. Different from diarrhea. Page 35.
Primary feathers	The long outer flight feathers. A wing clip shortens four to seven of them on each wing. Page 21.
Psittacosis	Parrot fever, caused by <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> . It can spread to people. Page 31.
PTFE	Polytetrafluoroethylene: the nonstick coating on many pans. Past 280°C (536°F) it gives off gases that damage a bird's lungs. Page 9.
Quarantine	Keeping a new bird apart, in a separate room on separate equipment, for 30 to 45 days. Page 24.
Thyroid	The gland that makes a hormone from iodine. It enlarges on an iodine-poor seed diet. Page 31.
Trichomonas	The parasite behind canker, a common cause of death in young budgies. Page 33.
Units	°F, degrees Fahrenheit, and °C, degrees Celsius, for temperature; in (inches), ft (feet) and cm (centimeters) for size; g (grams) for weight; % (percent) for shares of the diet.
Urates	The white or cream chalky part of a dropping: uric acid, how a bird excretes nitrogen while saving water. Page 35.
UV	Ultraviolet: light beyond what the eye sees. An indoor budgie away from unfiltered sunlight needs a full-spectrum UV light made for birds. Page 8.
Vent	The single opening that droppings and eggs both leave through. Page 35.
Xanthoma	A yellow, thickened, cholesterol-loaded patch of skin, linked to a high-fat diet. Page 30.
Zinc poisoning	Poisoning from galvanized cage hardware, once called "new wire disease." Page 10.
Zoonotic	Able to spread from animals to people. Psittacosis is. Page 31.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references

- Veterinary Centers of America (VCA Animal Hospitals): the feeding budgies, fruits and vegetables in bird diets, abnormal droppings, recognizing illness, household hazards, zinc poisoning, new bird visit, egg binding, chronic egg laying, sexual behavior, polyomavirus, PBFD, common conditions, kidney disorders, beak and nail care, wing clipping, blood or pin feathers, taming and training, clicker and target training, introducing a new bird, respiratory disease, nursing care, and transporting your bird pages.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: reproductive diseases, viral diseases, toxicoses, nutritional diseases, digestive and mycotic diseases, skin and feather disorders, management of pet birds, behavior, illness, and the popular pet birds table. PTFE at 280°C (536°F), the 90-day aviary quarantine, the wing clip method, and the avian gastric yeast figures.
- Lafeber and LafeberVet: the parakeet basic information sheet (weight, life span, clutch, incubation, body temperature, heart and breathing rates); female with blue cere; foods toxic to pet birds; cat bites; pet bird and parrot behavior; body condition scoring; the healthy-weight article by avian veterinarian Susan Orosz; reproductive emergencies; switching from seeds to pellets; grooming companion birds; psittacine behavior, handling and restraint; pin feathers.
- Association of Avian Veterinarians: the find-a-vet directory.
- University of Florida Small Animal Hospital: how to care for your pet bird. University of California, Davis, School of Veterinary Medicine: feather-picking in parrots. Veterinary Partner: environmental enrichment for birds.
- Niles Animal Hospital and Bird Medical Center (veterinarian Peter S. Sakas): iodine deficiency and goiter in birds, and megabacteriosis. Bird Vet Melbourne and Melbourne Bird Vet: caring for budgerigars and *Macrorhabdus*. New Plymouth Vet Group: feeding a budgerigar. Long Island Bird and Exotics Veterinary Clinic: budgie care. Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital: polyoma virus.
- Avian veterinarian Margaret A. Wissman, in the World Budgerigar Organisation's avian cancer article: the male cere and kidney tumors.

Research

- Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006), AFA Watchbird: the influence of the breeding method on the behavior of adult African grey parrots. Aydinonat and colleagues (2014), PLOS ONE: social isolation shortens telomeres in African grey parrots. Ebisawa and colleagues (2021), PLOS ONE: feather-damaging behavior in a Japanese nationwide survey of parrots.
- Turcu and colleagues (2023), Animals: feathers and oral swabs as DNA sources for molecular sexing. A 2023 case series on avian gastric yeast in cockatiels, budgerigars and grey parrots (PubMed Central). Ungurean and colleagues (2021), Current Biology: pupil behavior in birds.
- United States Department of Agriculture, Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service: the summary of studies for the avian polyomavirus vaccine.

Public health and safety

- National Association of State Public Health Veterinarians (NASPHV): the compendium of measures to control *Chlamydia psittaci* infection, 2009. The 30-day quarantine floor, the cleaning dilutions and contact times, and the doxycycline course. California Department of Food and Agriculture: pet bird care and disease prevention.
- Consumer Product Safety Commission and Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: carbon monoxide. National Weather Service: car interior heating.

Husbandry, cost and records

- PetMD: the budgie care sheet (cage size, UV light hours, bathing, toy rotation, time out of the cage) and how long parakeets live. Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals: enrichment for pet birds. Heartland Avian Rescue Project: costs of parrot ownership. Guinness World Records: the largest vocabulary for a bird. Retail prices were last checked in September 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Life span	5 to 10 years (a veterinary reference table); a mean of 7 to 15 (a veterinary information sheet); 10 to 12 with proper care (a pet-health site)	7 to 15 years
Minimum cage	18 in wide and long (a veterinary sheet); 18×18×18 in for one bird and 30×18×18 in for two (a pet-health site)	18×18×18 in, 30×18×18 in for a pair
Bar spacing	About 3/8 in (a veterinary sheet); half an inch or less (a pet-health site)	Half an inch or less
Fresh share of the diet	20 to 25% at most (the budgie feeding page); no more than 20 to 40% (a general bird diet page)	20 to 25%
Millet	Small quantities once or twice a month (a veterinary page); used as the everyday taming reward (care sheets)	Short pieces, counted, once or twice a month
Incubation	About 18 days (a budgerigar information sheet); 21 to 28 days (parrots in general)	About 18 days
Weight loss during a diet change	More than 1 to 2% in a week means too fast (a university hospital); more than 10% from the start means call a vet (a veterinary page)	Slow down at 1 to 2% a week; call the vet at 10%
Checkups	At least yearly; at least twice a year	Once a year is the floor; twice is stronger
Quarantine	30 days is the floor (a public health compendium); 30 to 45 days; 90 days for an aviary (polyomavirus shedding)	30 to 45 days; nearer 90 with other birds
Doxycycline course	45 days is the usual course; 30 days for a budgerigar	45 days; 30 for a budgerigar
Wing clipping	Trimming is encouraged to prevent escape (a pet-health site); a values call weighing safety against exercise (veterinary sources)	The owner's decision with a vet; both cases on page 21

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 51 pages. Safety: cage at least 18×18×18 in for one bird, about 30×18×18 in for a pair; bars half an inch or less apart; room 65 to 85°F (18 to 29°C), ideal 70 to 75°F (21 to 24°C); full-spectrum bird UV light 10 to 12 hours a day without unfiltered sunlight; diet change too fast above 1 to 2% weight lost in a week, vet at 10%; seed about 1 level teaspoon daily; egg binding warmth 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C); bleach 1 part to 32 parts water; pastel and solid-color cere mutations need a DNA test; first vet exam within one to two weeks, checkup yearly, twice better; medicine doses removed. Costs: setup \$165 to \$465 with the bird; first exam \$45 to \$65; \$19 to \$55 a month; bare-minimum first year about \$390. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: no more than 12 hours without eating; no preventive antibiotic in quarantine; doxycycline 30 days for a budgerigar; a broken blood feather handled with firm pressure, never pulled at home; daily weighing. Other changes are wording only. Replaced by 3.0.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Full rebuild, 39 pages. Diet rewritten around 60 to 80% pellets. Replaced by 2.1.
- **1.0, Aug 2026.** First edition, 20 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an avian veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home.

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